

Shared Suffering, Shared Peace? Refugee Return, Violent Displacement, and Communal Violence

Zhejun Qiu*

September 18, 2026

Abstract

Although refugee return is widely promoted as a durable solution to displacement, its consequences for local security and social order remain poorly understood. In particular, little is known about how return reshapes relations between returnees and stayees in conflict-affected communities. I argue that these consequences depend not only on what each group experienced during war, but also on how their wartime experiences compare. When both returnees and stayees experienced substantial violence, recognition of shared suffering can foster empathy and soften social boundaries, reducing the risk of communal conflict. When their exposure was asymmetric, return may instead generate perceived security threats or resentment over unequal wartime sacrifice. I evaluate this argument using settlement-level data on refugee return and communal violence in post-ISIS Iraq. Combining International Organization for Migration data from 2019–2022, ACLED event data, and a shift-share instrumental-variable strategy, I find that returns from conflict-affected Syria increase communal violence in communities with relatively low exposure to ISIS, but that this destabilizing effect is substantially reduced where stayees also experienced ISIS occupation. Survey evidence is consistent with the proposed mechanisms: shared exposure is associated with lower security concerns and less discrimination against returnees. The conflict-mitigating effect is also stronger where legal institutions address land disputes and facilitate returnee documentation. These findings show that the consequences of wartime violence are relational: the prospects for peaceful reintegration depend partly on how the wartime experiences of returning and receiving populations align.

Length: 50 pages, including the main text and appendix but excluding references and figures.

*PhD Candidate, Department of Political Science, University of Pittsburgh. Email: zhejunqiu@pitt.edu. I thank Burcu Savun, Alex Braithwaite, Rebecca Cordell, Jude Hays, William Spaniel, Chris Blair, Beth Whitaker, Ryan Welch, Blair Welsh, Miranda Simon, Noora Lori, Mary McThomas, Mae MacDonald, and Poonam Narewatt for helpful comments and suggestions. I also thank participants at the 2025 APSA Annual Meeting, the 2025 PSSI Annual Meeting, the 2026 SPSA Borders and Migration Conference Within a Conference, the 2026 ISA Annual Meeting, and the 2026 APSA Migration and Citizenship Dissertation Workshop. All errors are my own.

Introduction

The return of displaced populations is widely regarded as a cornerstone of post-conflict recovery.¹ Governments, international organizations, and humanitarian agencies promote repatriation as a means of restoring social order and rebuilding communities fractured by war (Ghosn et al., 2021; Black & Gent, 2006; Dadush, 2018; UNHCR, 2008). Yet return does not always produce reintegration. In some communities, returning populations are absorbed with little conflict; in others, return coincides with land disputes, social exclusion, and renewed communal violence (Schwartz, 2019; Blair & Wright, 2022; Saffon & Sánchez, 2019; Ruiz & Vargas-Silva, 2022). Why does the return of displaced populations destabilize some post-conflict communities but not others?

Existing explanations focus primarily on the structural pressures created by population return. Large return flows can intensify competition over scarce resources, unsettle wartime property arrangements, alter local demographic balances, and strain weak governing institutions (Black & Gent, 2006; Blair & Wright, 2022; Schwartz, 2019; Van Leeuwen & Van Der Haar, 2016). Returnees may also be stigmatized as outsiders or viewed as politically suspect, particularly where displacement has altered social hierarchies and political loyalties (Macdonald & Kerali, 2020; Kunuroglu et al., 2021). These accounts identify important sources of post-return tension, but pay less attention to how the wartime experiences of returnees and stayees shape their interactions after return. This omission matters because displacement does not necessarily remove refugees from war. Refugees may themselves experience armed violence, recruitment, detention, or persecution while displaced. Return can therefore bring together populations whose wartime experiences may differ considerably or overlap in important ways.

Research on the social legacies of violence suggests that this distinction may matter. Wartime victimization does not have uniformly conflictual consequences: exposure to violence can reinforce threat and hostility, but it can also strengthen cooperation and foster empathy toward others who have suffered (Bauer et al., 2014; Gilligan et al., 2014; Whitt et al., 2025). Yet much of this literature asks how violence changes those who experience it, rather than how the relationship between the wartime experiences of different groups shapes their subsequent interactions. How, then, does the alignment of wartime experiences between returnees and stayees shape the risk of communal conflict following return?

I argue that the consequences of refugee return depend on whether returnees and stayees experienced

¹I use refugee return and refugee repatriation interchangeably.

wartime violence in similar or different ways. When both groups endured substantial violence, shared suffering can foster empathy and soften social boundaries. Individuals who recognize that others endured hardships comparable to their own may be more likely to view returnees as fellow survivors rather than as outsiders, competitors, or people who escaped the costs of war. When one group experienced much greater wartime violence than the other, by contrast, return may reinforce suspicion and resentment. Stayees who suffered intensely may regard comparatively sheltered returnees as having avoided wartime sacrifices, while communities that experienced relative security may view returnees arriving from violent displacement environments as potential sources of insecurity. These asymmetric experiences can harden social boundaries and increase the risk that post-return disputes escalate into communal violence.

Building on research on “empathy born of violence” and common ingroup identity formation ([Hartman & Morse, 2020](#); [Hong et al., 2020](#)), I develop a relational framework of wartime exposure. The framework distinguishes three theoretically meaningful configurations. Shared exposure can create mutual recognition of victimization and weaken the returnee–stayee boundary. When returnees experienced substantial violence but stayees did not, returnees may instead be perceived as bringing insecurity into the community. When stayees suffered heavily but returnees experienced comparatively safer displacement, resentment over unequal wartime sacrifice can harden the boundary between the two groups. These configurations generate distinct expectations about when refugee return will heighten communal conflict and when shared wartime experience can mitigate it.

To evaluate these claims, I examine refugee return and communal violence in post-ISIS Iraq. Following the territorial defeat of the Islamic State, displaced Iraqis returned from host countries with different levels of wartime violence to communities that also varied in their exposure to ISIS. I combine settlement-level data on refugee return from the International Organization for Migration’s Integrated Location Assessments (2019–2022) with ACLED conflict-event data. To address the endogeneity of return, I employ a shift–share instrumental-variable strategy that combines preexisting settlement-level return patterns with shocks originating in refugees’ host countries to generate plausibly exogenous variation in return flows from different displacement environments. The results show that returns from conflict-affected Syria increase communal violence in communities with relatively low exposure to ISIS, but this destabilizing effect is substantially reduced where stayees also experienced ISIS occupation. Returns from comparatively peaceful host countries show the opposite conditional pattern: they become

more destabilizing as stayees' exposure to ISIS increases, providing suggestive evidence that asymmetric wartime experiences can harden social boundaries after return. Additional evidence from IOM surveys is consistent with the proposed mechanisms: where returnees from Syria and stayees share high wartime exposure, residents report lower security concerns and returnees experience less discrimination. The conflict-mitigating effect of shared exposure is also stronger in communities with legal institutions that address land disputes and facilitate returnee documentation.

A preregistered conjoint survey experiment in Ethiopia, currently underway and described in Appendix Section B, complements the Iraq analysis by directly testing the proposed individual-level mechanisms. Among communities affected by the Tigray War (2020–2022), the experiment varies hypothetical returnees' experiences of violence during displacement and examines whether their effects depend on respondents' own wartime exposure. It tests whether recognition of shared suffering increases acceptance of returnees, reduces perceived threat, and strengthens support for reintegration, while also examining whether these effects extend across ethnic boundaries. By evaluating the argument in a different conflict and social setting, the experiment also provides a test of the theory's broader applicability.

This study makes three contributions. First, it advances research on forced displacement by shifting attention from the characteristics of returnees or receiving communities considered separately to the relationship between their wartime experiences. Refugee return brings together populations whose experiences of war shape how they interpret one another's claims to security, resources, and belonging. The consequences of return therefore depend not only on the pressures created by population movement, but also on the wartime trajectories of the groups being reunited. Second, the paper contributes to research on the social legacies of violence by developing a relational account of wartime victimization. Existing research shows that exposure to violence can generate both hostility and prosocial behavior. I argue that part of this variation depends on whether survivors subsequently encounter others whose suffering resembles their own: shared exposure can foster mutual recognition and weaken social boundaries, whereas asymmetric exposure can reinforce threat and resentment. Third, the paper connects these social legacies to post-conflict institutions. The findings suggest that the pacifying potential of shared suffering is stronger where institutions can adjudicate disputes and secure returnees' rights, helping translate greater social acceptance into peaceful coexistence. More broadly, the paper shows that post-conflict order depends not only on how much violence societies have endured, but also on whether

the groups that must live together after war experienced that violence in similar or different ways.

Refugee Return and Communal Violence

A large literature examines the political and security consequences of refugee displacement for host societies, but considerably less is known about what happens when refugees return to their countries of origin. Research on return has focused primarily on the conditions that shape voluntary and forced repatriation (Camarena, 2024; Camarena & Hägerdal, 2020; Alrababah et al., 2023; Bove et al., 2022; Reilly & Risser, 2000). A smaller body of work examines what follows return, including its implications for security and political order (Long, 2013; Camarena, 2016). Returnees may face suspicion from governments (Bernstein, 2019), recruitment by armed groups (Haer & Hecker, 2019; Mills & Norton, 2002; Blattman & Annan, 2010), and exclusion by local communities that perceive them as outsiders (Schwartz, 2019). This paper focuses on one consequence of return that is comparatively understudied: its effect on communal violence in receiving communities.

Communal violence consists of violent events between identity-based non-state groups, distinguishing it from armed conflict between states and rebels, criminal competition, and anti-state protest (Elfvérsson, 2015; Brosché & Elfvérsson, 2012).² Displacement and return can make the distinction between those who fled and those who remained socially and politically salient, particularly when returnees are perceived as outsiders or as having different claims to resources, rights, and belonging (Schwartz, 2019; Tellez & Balcells, 2025). Return can therefore generate tensions directly surrounding reintegration while also reshaping existing cleavages among tribes, clans, ethnic groups, and religious communities (Fisk, 2019; Rüegger, 2019). The relevant outcome is thus not limited to direct clashes between returnees and stayees. Return may also alter broader patterns of communal conflict within receiving communities.

Existing research points to three recurring explanations for why return may destabilize communal relations: identity cleavages, demographic disruption, and competition over resources. First, displacement can create lasting distinctions between those who left and those who stayed. Returnees may be viewed as outsiders, politically suspect, or less entitled to participate in the postwar community, generating discrimination and mistrust (Schwartz, 2019). Second, large-scale return can alter the demographic balance of fragile communities. Much like refugee inflows into host countries, substantial return flows may in-

²Although the term “communal violence” originally referred primarily to clashes between ethnic and religious groups (De Juan et al., 2015; Fjelde & Østby, 2014), it has expanded to encompass organized identity-based violence involving livelihood groups and divisions between original inhabitants and newcomers (Raleigh, 2014; Brosché, 2023).

crease the size or local concentration of particular identity groups, alter political and social balances, and reactivate preexisting tensions (Fisk, 2019; Rüegger, 2019). Third, return can intensify competition over scarce resources, particularly land and property. Homes and land abandoned during displacement may have been occupied or redistributed, making attempts at restitution a source of local conflict (OHCHR, 2007; Van Leeuwen & Van Der Haar, 2016; Schwartz, 2019; Ruiz & Vargas-Silva, 2022). More broadly, aid and other resources associated with displacement and return can also generate perceptions of unequal treatment and intensify competition within receiving communities (Blair & Wright, 2022; Paler et al., 2020).

These explanations identify important pressures created by refugee return, but they say less about why similar return flows produce different consequences across communities. In particular, existing work generally treats the wartime experiences of returnees and stayees separately, or implicitly assumes that refugees escaped the violence endured by those who remained. That assumption is often unrealistic. Displacement does not necessarily remove refugees from war: refugees, particularly in the Global South, may themselves encounter armed violence, recruitment, terrorism, persecution, or renewed displacement while abroad (Faulkner, 2016; Haer & Hecker, 2019; Gineste & Savun, 2019; Fisk, 2019). Return can therefore bring together populations whose wartime exposure was either substantially different or similar in important respects.

This variation matters because the same pressures identified by existing theories—competition over land, demographic change, or disputes over belonging—may be interpreted differently depending on how returnees’ and stayees’ wartime experiences compare. Yet existing research provides little account of how the *alignment* of these experiences shapes relations after return. In the next section, I develop a relational theory of wartime exposure, distinguishing between shared and asymmetric exposure to violence and explaining when these configurations are more likely to foster empathy and boundary softening or, alternatively, threat perceptions, resentment, and exclusion.

Violent Displacement Experiences and Post-Return Communal Violence

Refugee return brings together populations whose trajectories through war may have been very different. Some returnees spent displacement in relatively secure environments, while others encountered armed

conflict, persecution, detention, or renewed displacement. Stayees likewise vary in the violence they experienced at home. I argue that these experiences matter relationally: the consequences of return depend not only on what either group experienced, but also on how returnees' and stayees' wartime experiences compare. The same experience of displacement may therefore shape post-return relations differently depending on whether stayees recognize it as similar to, or different from, what they themselves endured.³

This argument builds on a tension in research on the legacies of political violence. Existing research on the legacies of wartime violence provides mixed evidence about its effects on intergroup attitudes and behavior. One line of scholarship emphasizes a "post-traumatic stress" pathway, suggesting that exposure to violence can hinder post-conflict recovery by inducing depression and reinforcing intergroup prejudice and hostility (Blattman & Annan, 2010; Hoffman et al., 2019; Homola et al., 2020; Krick, 2026). In contrast, research on "empathy born of violence" argues that direct or indirect exposure to violence can increase preferences for peace and promote interpersonal and intergroup altruism (Hartman & Morse, 2020; Alvarez & Homola, 2025; Batson et al., 2002). Yet suffering does not necessarily generate empathy toward others. Perspective-taking can be difficult across entrenched group boundaries, and in some settings intergroup rivalry can produce indifference or even counter-empathic responses to another group's suffering (Cikara et al., 2014).

One possible explanation for these divergent effects is that much of this research focuses on how violence changes those who experience it, without considering how their experiences compare with those of groups they subsequently encounter. Yet the social meaning of wartime suffering may depend partly on whether it is shared across groups and whether that common experience is recognized (Dinas et al., 2021b; Nadler et al., 2008). I therefore distinguish between *shared* and *asymmetric* exposure to wartime violence.

Shared exposure occurs when returnees experienced substantial violence during displacement and stayees also experienced substantial violence at home. Asymmetric exposure occurs when one group experienced considerably more wartime violence than the other. The same returnee experience can therefore have different implications depending on the receiving community. Exposure to violence dur-

³Violent experiences also shape refugees' decisions to return. Pre-displacement exposure may deter return, whereas insecurity in host communities may compel it; attachment to one's place of origin may simultaneously increase wartime exposure and motivate eventual return (Ghosh et al., 2021; Alrababah et al., 2023; Dandy et al., 2019). These dynamics create potential endogeneity between wartime experiences and who returns, which I address in the research design. Here, I focus on how the alignment of returnees' and stayees' wartime exposure conditions communal conflict after return.

ing displacement may become a basis for solidarity when stayees recognize it as resembling their own experience, but a source of suspicion when stayees have little comparable experience. Conversely, returnees who spent displacement in relative safety may encounter little resentment in communities that also experienced limited violence, but may be viewed differently by stayees who endured severe wartime suffering.

My argument depends not simply on similarity in wartime exposure but on whether that similarity is *recognized*. Shared exposure creates an opportunity for returnees and stayees to understand one another as people who endured comparable hardships; it does not guarantee that they will do so. Differences in identity, political narratives, or information about what the other group experienced may inhibit such recognition. Shared exposure should therefore be understood as a condition that can facilitate empathy and changes in social boundaries rather than as a deterministic source of reconciliation. Likewise, asymmetric exposure does not inevitably produce conflict. Resource competition, property disputes, institutions, and preexisting cleavages continue to shape post-return relations. The claim is that the alignment of wartime experiences affects how these pressures are interpreted and, consequently, how likely they are to escalate.

These distinctions produce four configurations of returnee and stayee exposure, summarized in Table 1.⁴

Returnees Stayees	High local wartime exposure	Low local wartime exposure
	Shared exposure (empathy, boundary softening) ⇒ violence ↓ H1	Threat perception (suspicion, stigma) ⇒ violence ↑ H2
Low displacement violence exposure	Boundary hardening (resentment, exclusion) ⇒ violence ↑ H3	Low-exposure baseline ⇒ indeterminate

Table 1: Expected communal violence by returnee and stayee wartime exposure profiles

Shared Exposure: Empathy and Boundary Softening

The top-left cell captures shared exposure, where both returnees and stayees experienced high levels of wartime violence. I argue that shared exposure can mitigate post-return conflict through two related mechanisms: *empathy* and *ingroup recategorization*. Both depend on the recognition of shared suffering.

⁴My theory focuses on situations where at least one group experienced high levels of wartime violence. When both returnees and stayees faced relatively low exposure (the bottom-right cell), differences in wartime suffering should play a less important role in shaping post-return relations, so I do not make a directional prediction.

Experiencing violence does not necessarily make individuals more empathetic toward others as victimization can also reinforce mistrust and hostility. Rather, prior suffering may provide a basis for empathy when individuals recognize similarities between their own experiences and those of another group.

The first mechanism is empathy. Empathy—the capacity to recognize and respond to others’ suffering—can promote cooperation and prosocial behavior in conflict-affected societies (De Waal, 2008; Decety & Jackson, 2006; Goetz et al., 2010). A related literature on “post-traumatic growth” suggests that exposure to severe hardship can, under some conditions, lead individuals to reassess priorities, strengthen interpersonal bonds, and place greater value on collective well-being (Bauer et al., 2016; Grosjean, 2014; Whitt et al., 2025). Experiences of violence and wartime solidarity may therefore increase responsiveness to others’ suffering when victims perceive their experiences as comparable (Staub & Vollhardt, 2008; Tellez & Balcells, 2025; Canevello et al., 2022; Hartman & Morse, 2020; Dinas et al., 2021a; Ghosn et al., 2019). This logic has particular relevance for refugee return. Returnees and stayees must renegotiate social relations after having experienced the war from different places. Stayees may view returnees as people who escaped the costs of conflict, benefited from assistance abroad, or remained sheltered from violence at home. Learning that returnees themselves encountered violence during displacement can alter those perceptions. Returnees who fled from one site of violence to another may be understood less as people who avoided wartime hardship and more as fellow victims of the conflict. Returnees who endured violence while displaced may likewise be better able to recognize the losses of those who remained. When such recognition occurs, shared suffering can reduce social distance and increase willingness to cooperate over reintegration and resources in war-affected communities.

The second mechanism through which shared violent experiences can reduce communal conflict is ingroup re-categorization, which I refer to as boundary softening: a shift in the returnee–stayee social boundary that broadens the definition of the ingroup. Displacement can create or sharpen a social boundary between those who fled and those who remained. Stayees may perceive returnees as outsiders who benefited from aid, avoided hardship, or adopted different norms and practices while abroad, weakening prewar trust and generating resentment (Schwartz, 2019). Social identity theory emphasizes that individuals categorize themselves and others according to perceived similarities and differences (Tajfel, 1979; Turner, 1985), while the common ingroup identity model suggests that shared experiences can make a broader, more inclusive identity salient (Gaertner et al., 1993; Dovidio et al., 2008). Recogni-

tion of comparable wartime suffering can therefore weaken the returnee–stayee distinction as a basis for exclusion by allowing returnees to be understood not only as people who left, but also as fellow victims or survivors of the same broader conflict. This form of recategorization does not require existing group identities to disappear. Returnees and stayees may continue to differ along ethnic, sectarian, political, or other lines. Rather, shared suffering can make an additional, more inclusive category salient enough to reduce the importance of the returnee–stayee boundary. Reconciliation efforts in post-genocide Rwanda, for example, have sought to emphasize losses across groups as part of efforts to construct a broader sense of common victimhood and coexistence (Eltringham, 2004; Staub, 2006). Whether such recategorization occurs should depend partly on whether the suffering of the other group is regarded as credible and comparable—a scope condition I return to below when considering identity cleavages.

Whereas empathy reduces social distance by making others’ suffering morally salient, boundary softening (or re-categorization) expands who is regarded as part of “us” by weakening categorical distinctions between returnees and stayees. The two processes are complementary. Empathy can facilitate cooperation, while boundary softening can help sustain it by weakening the social divisions that make exclusion more likely. However, neither process eliminates disputes over land, resources, or political standing. Rather, shared suffering can make such disputes less likely to be interpreted through a rigid returnee–stayee divide and therefore less likely to escalate into communal violence.⁵

H1 (Shared exposure): *Refugee return will be less likely to generate communal violence when returnees’ displacement-related exposure and stayees’ local wartime exposure are both high than when returnees experienced high violence during displacement but stayees experienced comparatively low wartime violence.*

Asymmetric Exposure: Perceived Security Threat

The top-right cell captures an asymmetric exposure configuration in which returnees experienced high levels of violence during displacement, while stayees experienced comparatively low local wartime violence. In this setting, returnees’ experiences provide less basis for recognition of shared suffering and may instead become associated with insecurity. Stayees who were relatively insulated from wartime violence may have limited direct experience with the environments from which returnees arrive. Information that

⁵A real-world illustration comes from Sinjar in northern Iraq. After the ISIS massacre of the Yazidi community, local people developed empathy toward other war victims based on their own traumatic experiences. They established NGOs such as [Nadia’s Initiative](#) to support other survivors, especially by facilitating return through community-centered development and infrastructure programs aimed at rebuilding a shared sense of belonging. As a result, shared victimhood is less likely to be mobilized for exclusion and more likely to support coexistence, reducing the risk that return-related disputes escalate into communal violence.

returnees lived amid armed conflict, persecution, or political violence may therefore heighten uncertainty about the security consequences of their return. Indirect exposure to wartime violence through media, rumors, and broader threat narratives can generate strong perceptions of intergroup threat even among those who were not directly exposed (Huddy et al., 2002).

This mechanism does not require returnees to pose an actual security risk. Rather, their association with violent displacement environments may become a signal through which stayees assess uncertainty about renewed conflict. Returnees may be suspected of ties to armed groups, involvement in unresolved wartime disputes, vulnerability to retaliation, or other connections that could bring violence into the community (Ambrosius & Meseguer, 2020). Research on intergroup threat similarly shows that perceived threats to security and group well-being can generate suspicion and exclusion even when those threats are uncertain or indirect (Stephan et al., 2000; Krick, 2026). Without a shared experience of violence that might counter these perceptions, returnees can therefore be stigmatized as potential sources of instability. Such perceptions can make post-return disputes more likely to escalate. Stayees who associate returnees with insecurity may be less willing to accept their return, accommodate their claims, or cooperate with them, and may respond defensively or preemptively. Returnees who anticipate suspicion and exclusion may in turn become less willing to trust local residents or institutions. The resulting reciprocal mistrust can heighten intergroup tension and increase the likelihood that disputes surrounding return escalate into communal violence.

H2 (Threat perception): *Compared with areas without refugee return, communal violence will be more likely in areas experiencing large-scale return when returnees experienced high levels of violence during displacement but stayees experienced comparatively low levels of local wartime violence.*

Asymmetric Exposure: Unequal Sacrifice and Boundary Hardening

The bottom-left cell captures the opposite exposure asymmetry: stayees endured high levels of local wartime violence, while returnees are perceived to have experienced comparatively safer conditions during displacement. In this configuration, stayees may evaluate returnees through perceptions of unequal wartime sacrifice. Those who endured occupation, violence, or prolonged insecurity may view returnees as having avoided costs that people who remained were forced to bear. These comparisons can become especially salient when returnees seek to reclaim property, obtain assistance, compete for employment,

or recover political and social standing. Claims that might otherwise be regarded as legitimate aspects of reintegration may instead be viewed as demands by people who did not bear comparable wartime burdens.

Perceptions of unequal sacrifice can, in turn, harden the social boundary between those who stayed and those who left. Returnees may be regarded as less deserving of scarce resources or as less legitimate members of the postwar community. Exposure to severe violence may intensify these reactions when trauma and loss make differences in wartime experience particularly salient (Hoffman et al., 2019). The mechanism, however, is relational rather than simply a consequence of victimization: resentment arises from the comparison between what stayees believe they endured and what they believe returnees avoided. As resentment and exclusion become attached to the returnee–stayee divide, disputes surrounding return are more likely to escalate into communal violence.⁶

H3 (Boundary hardening): *Refugee return from comparatively low-violence displacement environments will be associated with a greater risk of communal violence where stayees experienced high levels of local wartime violence than where stayees experienced comparatively low levels of wartime violence.*

Research Design

Settlement-Level Evidence from Iraq

To evaluate my hypotheses, I construct a settlement-round panel of Iraqi communities following the territorial defeat of the Islamic State (ISIS). The design exploits two dimensions of variation that correspond to the theory: whether refugees returned from displacement environments characterized by high or comparatively low levels of violence, and whether the communities receiving them had themselves experienced ISIS occupation. I combine settlement-level assessments from the International Organization for Migration’s Integrated Location Assessment (ILA) with geocoded conflict events from ACLED. The main analysis covers ILA Rounds IV–VII (2019–2022), when the ILA consistently identifies Iraqi refugees returning from abroad and records the countries where they had been living before return. The unit of analysis is the settlement-round. Throughout the paper, *refugee returnees* refers to Iraqis returning from outside the country, distinct from internally displaced returnees, whom the IOM records separately.

⁶Both asymmetric exposure configurations can increase communal violence, but through different mechanisms. Under H2, perceived security threats can generate uncertainty and incentives for preemptive exclusion. Under H3, resentment over unequal wartime sacrifice can harden the returnee–stayee boundary and intensify disputes over resources, rights, and belonging.

Iraq provides useful leverage for evaluating the argument for three reasons. First, the country experienced substantial refugee return following the territorial defeat of ISIS in 2017, with returns reaching their first major peak in late 2019 (IOM, 2023). Approximately 92% of returnees resettled in their communities of origin. Returning to places of origin does not eliminate selection into whether and when refugees return, but it reduces the scope for returnees to choose among Iraqi destinations based on contemporaneous local security conditions. I address the remaining endogeneity concerns below. Second, Iraqi refugees returned from host environments with substantially different levels of wartime violence, providing variation in displacement-related exposure. Third, the ILA records former host country alongside detailed settlement-level information on return flows, local institutions, public services, social tensions, and relations among displaced, returning, and resident populations.

Returnees' former host countries provide contextual information about their likely exposure to violence during displacement. As Figure 1 shows, beginning in 2018, more than 11,000 Iraqis were repatriated from northeastern Syria. Many had spent part of their displacement in highly insecure environments marked by armed conflict, detention, recruitment risks, and violence.⁷ By contrast, more than 24,000 Iraqis returned from European countries, particularly Germany and Sweden, where they lived in substantially more secure environments (Jones et al., 2022). The main analysis therefore distinguishes returns from conflict-affected Syria from returns from other, comparatively more secure host countries, primarily Turkey and European states.⁸

Host-country origin is necessarily an imperfect measure of wartime experience. It captures the broader environment in which refugees lived rather than whether a particular individual was directly victimized. The design therefore does not assume that every Iraqi refugee in Syria personally experienced violence or that refugees elsewhere experienced none. Rather, it uses former host country as a contextual proxy for differences in the likelihood and intensity of exposure to armed violence during displacement. This distinction parallels the settlement-level measure of stayee exposure developed below. Because former host country may also capture differences in refugees' economic resources, migration trajectories, or identity composition, I examine these alternative explanations in subsequent analyses.

Figure 2 provides descriptive context for the analysis. The top panel plots refugee return alongside

⁷A prominent example is al-Hawl camp in northeastern Syria, where conditions were marked by poor infrastructure, insecurity, and widespread human-rights abuses (Parry et al., 2022; IOM, 2022). See *Deutsche Welle* for additional background.

⁸Supplementary Figure A1 presents temporal trends in Iraqi refugee return by former host country.

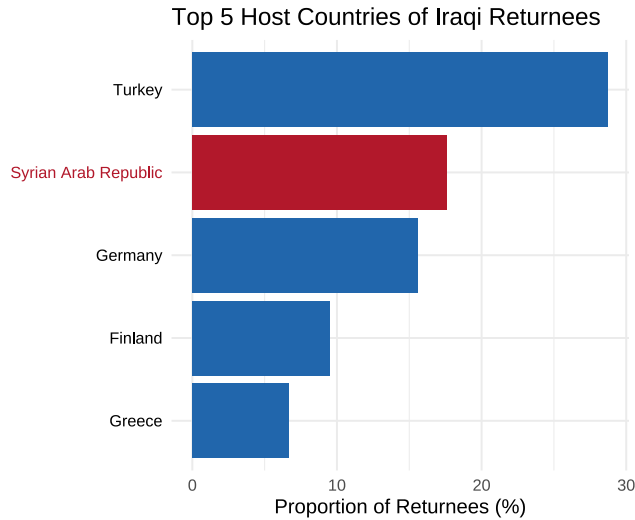


Figure 1: Major Host Countries of Iraqi Returnees

communal violence in Iraq from 2016 to 2023. Communal violence increased beginning in late 2019, around the time refugee return reached its first major peak. The maps in the bottom panels reveal substantial geographic heterogeneity in both return and violence. Some southeastern border districts receiving large return flows experienced increases in communal clashes, whereas several northern districts receiving similarly large flows did not. These patterns are descriptive and do not establish that refugee return caused the observed violence. They instead illustrate the variation that motivates the analysis: similar levels of return can coincide with very different security outcomes across receiving communities.

The primary data source is the IOM’s Integrated Location Assessment ([International Organization for Migration \(IOM\), 2021](#)), conducted in successive rounds by the IOM’s Rapid Assessment and Response Teams. The ILA records the presence and characteristics of displaced and returning populations across Iraqi settlements. Assessed settlements include rural villages, urban neighborhoods, and camps in which at least one internally displaced person or returnee was recorded during the relevant assessment period. Figure 3 illustrates the spatial coverage of ILA Round V; the red points identify 334 settlements, approximately 10% of assessed sites, that hosted refugees returning from abroad.

The analysis begins with ILA Round IV, conducted in 2019, because it is the first round to systematically identify refugees returning from abroad and record their former host countries.⁹ A central advantage of the ILA is that it records returnees by former host country while also measuring settlement-

⁹Rounds I–III are excluded for measurement reasons. Round III reports the stock of returnees as of mid-2018 but does not consistently identify their former host countries or establish whether they returned following the territorial defeat of ISIS. Some returnees recorded in that round had returned before ISIS emerged. Rounds I and II do not contain questions on international refugee return. Coding these earlier rounds as containing no refugee returnees would therefore misrepresent both the timing and scale of return.

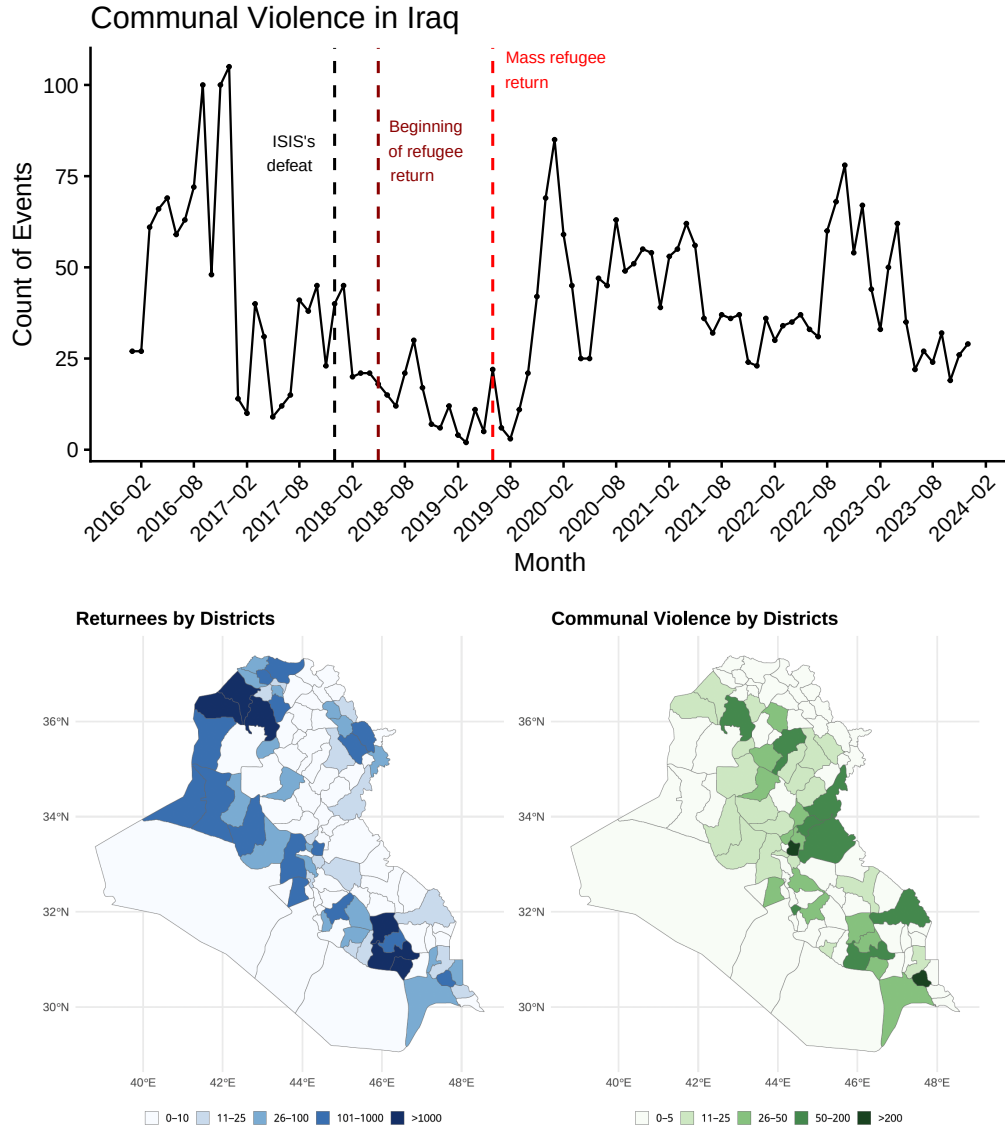


Figure 2: Refugee Return and Communal Violence in Iraq (2016–2023)

level social and institutional conditions. These measures include physical attacks, threats, mistrust, discrimination, public-service provision, local governance, legal institutions, aid distribution, and relations among returnees, stayees, and IDPs. I combine these assessments with ACLED events occurring within 5 kilometers of each settlement to construct the primary measure of communal violence between identity-based non-state groups (Raleigh et al., 2010).

Measurement and Estimation Strategies

Dependent Variable

I measure communal violence using geocoded event data from ACLED (Raleigh et al., 2010), guided

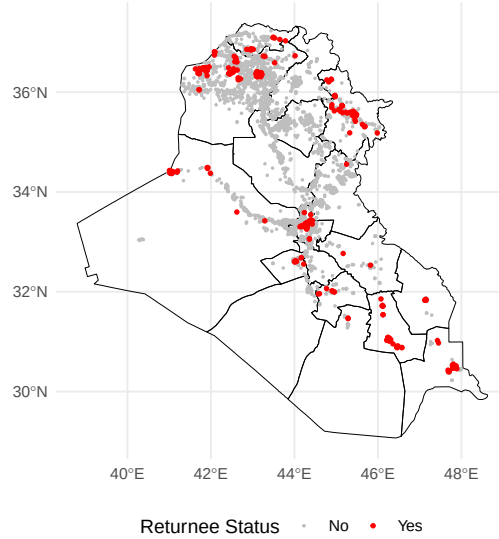


Figure 3: Settlements Covered in ILA Round V

by the Social Conflict Analysis Database’s (SCAD) definition of “extra-governmental violence” as armed clashes between political or social militias and one-sided violence carried out by organized non-state actors (Salehyan et al., 2012). In the Iraqi context, this captures identity-based non-state violence such as inter-communal fighting, sectarian clashes, and tribal disputes. For each settlement-round, I identify qualifying ACLED events occurring within a 5-kilometer radius of the ILA settlement and code the primary outcome as an indicator for whether at least one such event occurred.¹⁰

The ACLED measure is intentionally broader than violence explicitly identified as involving returnees. Refugee return may affect communal relations not only through direct clashes between returnees and stayees but also by intensifying existing sectarian, tribal, or other intergroup tensions within receiving communities. At the same time, this broader measure creates two potential concerns: events within a 5-kilometer radius may not be directly connected to the settlement, and event-based data may miss locally salient tensions or incidents that receive little public reporting. I therefore assess robustness using a more restrictive 2.5-kilometer radius and, separately, survey-based reports from IOM informants that more directly capture intergroup tensions involving displaced and resident populations.¹¹ The results are robust to both alternative measures (Appendix Sections A.6 and A.12).

Key Explanatory Variables

¹⁰Because ACLED does not include a distinct category for communal violence, I follow SCAD’s definition of “extra-governmental violence” and aggregate two types of events: (1) armed clashes between political or social militias and (2) identity-based one-sided violence perpetrated by political or social militias.

¹¹For a detailed discussion of the limitations of the ILA survey measure of communal violence—and the rationale for treating it as a secondary measure rather than the primary dependent variable—see Appendix Section A.16.

The central explanatory variable is the alignment between returnees' displacement-related exposure to violence and stayees' local wartime exposure. I operationalize this alignment using two sources of contextual variation: the number of refugees returning from host countries characterized by different levels of armed violence and whether the receiving settlement experienced ISIS occupation. Because neither measure identifies individual victimization, the analysis captures contextual rather than individual exposure to wartime violence.

To capture variation in returnees' displacement environments, I distinguish between returns from conflict-affected Syria and returns from other, comparatively more secure host countries, primarily Turkey and European states. Iraqi refugees in Syria were concentrated in areas affected by civil war, insurgency, terrorist violence, repeated displacement, and the presence of armed groups. These environments were substantially more violent than those in most other host countries and more closely resembled the wartime environments of stayees in ISIS-affected Iraqi communities.¹² By contrast, Iraqi refugees in other host countries generally lived in more secure environments, although they could still face detention, discrimination, criminal violence, or other forms of insecurity.

For stayees, I measure local wartime exposure using a binary indicator of whether the settlement experienced ISIS territorial control between 2014 and 2017, based on ILA Round III data.¹³ This measure likewise captures community-level rather than individual exposure. Figure 4 provides evidence for its validity: civilian fatalities attributable to ISIS between 2014 and 2017, measured using UCDP data within 5 kilometers of each settlement, were substantially higher in ISIS-occupied settlements, particularly those that remained under ISIS control for more than two years (Sundberg & Melander, 2013). Prior ISIS occupation therefore provides a plausible proxy for the intensity of the wartime environment experienced by receiving communities.

ISIS occupation was not randomly assigned, and settlements that came under ISIS control may differ systematically from those that did not. Because occupation occurred before the study period and does not vary across ILA rounds, settlement fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences across settlements that may be correlated with prior ISIS control. To allow the consequences of those preexisting differences to vary over time, I also interact ISIS occupation with survey-round indicators. These adjustments do not

¹²Appendix Section A.3 compares Syrian districts with recorded Iraqi refugee presence to UCDP conflict events after 2011. Iraqi refugees were concentrated in areas heavily affected by both ISIS expansion and anti-government violence during the Syrian civil war.

¹³In robustness analyses, I replace this binary measure with continuous measures of exposure, including the duration of ISIS occupation.

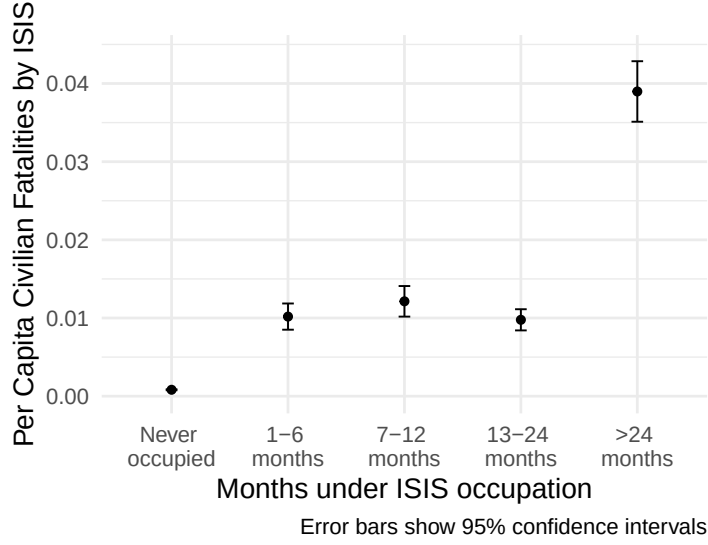


Figure 4: ISIS Occupation and Civilian Fatalities

require treating ISIS occupation as exogenous. Identification of the conditional relationship comes from changes in return flows within settlements and from whether those changes have different consequences across settlements with different pre-return wartime exposure. I address the remaining endogeneity of refugee return through the instrumental-variable strategy described below.

The baseline specification estimates how the relationship between refugee return and communal violence varies with stayees' prior exposure to ISIS. Let i index settlements, g governorates, and t ILA survey rounds. The return variables are the logged numbers of refugees returning from Syria and from other host countries, respectively.¹⁴

Here, $\gamma_{i,g}$ denotes settlement fixed effects and $\tau_{g,t}$ governorate-by-round fixed effects. Settlement fixed effects absorb all time-invariant settlement characteristics, while governorate-by-round fixed effects account for shocks common to settlements within the same governorate and survey round. Standard errors are clustered at the settlement level.

The interaction coefficients provide the central tests of the theory. β_2 captures how the effect of returns from conflict-affected Syria differs between settlements that did and did not experience ISIS occupation. A negative β_2 is consistent with H1: the destabilizing effect of return from a violent displacement environment should be weaker when stayees also experienced substantial wartime violence. Conversely,

¹⁴The ILA records the stock of returnees present at the time of each assessment, generally conducted near the middle of the year, but does not report their exact arrival dates. Because some returnees may have arrived months earlier and communal tensions may emerge soon after return, the main analysis measures violence during the same settlement-round period rather than imposing a lag that could misclassify the relevant exposure window. To address concerns about reverse causality, and additionally show in Columns 3–4 of Appendix Table A13 that the results persist when the outcome is restricted to communal violence occurring after the assessment, during the second half of the year.

β_4 captures how the effect of returns from comparatively more secure host countries differs with prior ISIS occupation; H3 predicts a positive interaction when stayees experienced greater wartime violence than returnees. The main effect β_1 captures the relationship between returns from Syria and communal violence in settlements without prior ISIS occupation, corresponding to the asymmetric configuration in H2.

$$Y_{i,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot ViolentHostReturn_{i,g,t} + \beta_2 \cdot ViolentHostReturn_{i,g,t} \times ISIS\ Exposure_{i,g} + \\ \beta_3 \cdot NonviolentHostReturn_{i,g,t} + \beta_4 \cdot NonviolentHostReturn_{i,g,t} \times ISIS\ Exposure_{i,g} + \\ X_{i,g,t} \cdot \beta + \tau_{t,g} + \gamma_{i,g} + \epsilon_{i,t}$$

Potential Confounders

A number of time-varying settlement characteristics could be associated with both refugee return and communal violence. The full specifications therefore account for displacement pressure, local services, economic conditions, ethno-sectarian composition, and contemporaneous conflict. To capture population pressure and mobility, I control for the numbers of refugees, internally displaced persons (IDPs), and IDP returnees in each settlement, together with an index of public-service provision, including water and sanitation.¹⁵ I measure local economic conditions using annual nighttime-light intensity from the Earth Observation Group.

To account for the local ethno-sectarian context, I use geocoded maps from the Gulf 2000 Project documenting the distribution of ethnic, linguistic, and sectarian groups across Iraq (Izady, 2024). A settlement is coded as multi-group when it overlaps with more than one identity group.¹⁶ Finally, I account for contemporaneous political violence using UCDP measures of anti-regime conflict and one-sided violence by government forces. All spatial measures not drawn directly from the ILA are aggregated within 5 kilometers of each settlement: I use averages for gridded measures such as nighttime lights and binary indicators for conflict events and ethno-sectarian composition.

¹⁵Following Anderson (2008), I construct the service-provision index using inverse-covariance weights across the component indicators.

¹⁶Identity context may also condition the effect of shared exposure; I examine this heterogeneity in the section on conditional effects.

Addressing the Endogeneity of Returnee Presence

Refugee return is unlikely to be randomly distributed across settlements. Selection can occur both in who returns and in where returnees resettle, potentially confounding the relationship between return and communal violence (Alrababah et al., 2023; Ghosn et al., 2021; Bove et al., 2022). Refugees with stronger attachments to their places of origin and denser social networks (Ghosn et al., 2019; De Dominicis et al., 2015), fewer security concerns (Camarena & Hägerdal, 2020), or poorer economic opportunities and living conditions in host countries (Arias et al., 2014) may be more likely to return. Returnees may also differ in where they resettle: some return to conflict-affected communities of origin (Ghosn et al., 2021), whereas others relocate to safer or more economically attractive areas (Bove et al., 2022; Walk et al., 2023).

To address this selection, I exploit changes in conditions outside Iraq that affect the likelihood of return but are not themselves determined by conditions in receiving settlements. Previous research has used host-country conditions, such as tightened migration controls (Ambrosius & Meseguer, 2020; Ambrosius & Leblang, 2020) and economic downturns (Bucheli et al., 2019), as plausibly exogenous sources of variation in refugee return. At the same time, return flows often exhibit strong path dependence (Simon, 2019; Rodríguez-Pose & Von Berlepsch, 2020): refugees tend to follow earlier cohorts back to familiar or previously reoccupied localities, even when other destinations might offer greater security or economic opportunity. These two features—time-varying conditions in host countries and persistent geographic patterns of return—provide the basis for the shift-share design.

Building on these insights, I implement a shift-share instrumental-variable design following Nunn & Qian (2014). The instrument interacts time-varying changes in conditions facing Iraqi refugees abroad (the shift”) with settlement-specific patterns of prior return (the share”). The intuition is that a common shock in a host country should generate larger changes in return to Iraqi settlements with stronger prior return linkages to that host.

For returns from Syria, the instrument is

$$IV_{i,t}^{Syria} = HostInstability_{t-1} \times Share_{i,t-1}^{Syria},$$

where $HostInstability_{t-1}$ measures conflict events between survey rounds in Syrian governorates

hosting Iraqi refugees. Deteriorating security in these areas increases pressure to leave Syria for reasons originating outside the receiving settlements in Iraq. $Share_{i,t-1}^{Syria}$ captures settlement i 's prior propensity to receive returnees from Syria.¹⁷ The instrument therefore predicts larger return flows following deteriorating conditions in Syria in settlements with stronger preexisting links to Syrian return migration.

For returnees from other host countries, I construct two additional instruments based on external policy changes in the European Union and Turkey, two major host destinations for Iraqi refugees:

$$\mathbf{IV}_{it}^{Others} = \begin{pmatrix} EU \text{ Recognition Rate}_{t-1} \times Share_{i,t-1}^{OtherHosts} \\ Turkey \text{ Res. Permit}_{t-1} \times Share_{i,t-1}^{OtherHosts} \end{pmatrix}.$$

where $EU \text{ Recognition Rate}_{t-1}$ is the average asylum-recognition rate across EU member states between survey waves $t - 1$ and t ,¹⁸ and $Turkey \text{ Res. Permit}_{t-1}$ is the number of Iraqi nationals holding residence permits in Turkey in the year preceding the survey, identified by Turkey's Directorate General of Migration Management (DGMM).¹⁹ These external shocks affect the likelihood of return from Europe and Turkey. $Share_{i,t-1}^{OtherHosts}$ captures locality i 's prior propensity to receive returnees from other host countries, based on all survey rounds preceding t .²⁰

The identification strategy relies on the assumption that the shift component captures plausibly exogenous, time-varying shocks that differentially affect return intensity across localities according to their preexisting share of returnees. The exclusion restriction requires that, conditional on the controls and fixed effects, these shocks affect communal violence in Iraqi settlements only through the return flows they induce. This assumption would be violated, for example, if changes in conflict in Syria or refugee policy in Europe and Turkey were systematically correlated with time-varying determinants of communal violence in particular Iraqi settlements for reasons unrelated to return. I therefore include the underlying return-share measures and their interactions with prior ISIS occupation. Settlement fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences across receiving communities, while governorate-by-round fixed effects absorb shocks common to settlements within the same governorate and survey round.

¹⁷In the main analysis, I use a time-varying measure of the share component. As an alternative identification strategy, I also use a time-invariant share component capturing each settlement's share of returnees in the earliest available ILA survey round (Appendix Section A.9). The results remain consistent.

¹⁸Data can be retrieved from the [EUAA official website](#).

¹⁹Data can be retrieved from the annual reports of [IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix, Unit in the Republic of Turkey](#).

²⁰Return may also be driven by improving economic or security conditions in Iraq rather than deteriorating conditions abroad. The instrumental-variable strategy does not assume otherwise. Instead, it isolates variation in return associated with changes in host-country conditions that alter refugees' incentives or ability to remain abroad. These shocks therefore help reduce concerns that observed return flows are driven entirely by refugees' endogenous responses to conditions in receiving communities.

I assess the plausibility of these identifying assumptions in several ways. First, I examine whether settlements with different prior propensities to receive returnees differ systematically on predetermined characteristics. Second, following Gehring et al. (2022), I examine whether trends in communal violence across settlements with different historical return propensities move systematically with external host-country shocks. Third, I re-estimate the 2SLS models using alternative instruments, including alternative host-country shocks that affect refugee return and a time-invariant share component capturing each settlement's share of returnees in the earliest ILA survey round. Appendix Sections A.17 and A.9 report these diagnostic analyses. I also report the first-stage estimates for the main analysis in Appendix Section A.10. Taken together, these results provide additional support for the identifying strategy, although the exclusion restriction cannot be tested directly.

Results

	OLS					IV		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.072** (0.028)		0.091*** (0.024)	0.088*** (0.025)	0.083*** (0.023)	0.100*** (0.029)	0.188*** (0.071)	0.189** (0.077)
Other Return (Logged)		-0.050*** (0.011)	-0.053*** (0.011)	-0.048*** (0.011)	-0.053*** (0.011)	-0.030** (0.014)	-0.063*** (0.021)	-0.063* (0.037)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.066** (0.033)		-0.085*** (0.030)	-0.081*** (0.029)	-0.072*** (0.027)	-0.078** (0.033)	-0.177** (0.072)	-0.210*** (0.077)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation		0.052*** (0.013)	0.054*** (0.013)	0.044*** (0.013)	0.048*** (0.014)	0.032* (0.018)	0.066*** (0.022)	0.025 (0.034)
Full Control				✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV					✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Full	Full	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics							2.102 (p = 0.35)	0.644 (p = 0.725)
Num. obs.	12080	12080	12080	12080	12080	1768	12080	1768

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Note. The unit of analysis is governorate-settlement-round. All models include settlement and governorate-by-round fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the settlement level.

Table 2: Refugee Return, Wartime Exposure, and Communal Violence
(ACLED Events)

Table 2 presents OLS and instrumental-variable estimates of the relationship between refugee return and communal violence. Columns 1 and 2 first examine returns from Syria and from other host countries separately, allowing each relationship to vary with prior ISIS occupation. In settlements that were not occupied by ISIS, returns from Syria are associated with a significantly higher probability of communal violence. The interaction between returns from Syria and ISIS occupation is negative and similar in magnitude to the main effect, indicating that this destabilizing relationship is substantially attenuated

in communities where stayees also experienced ISIS occupation. This pattern is consistent with H2 and H1: returns from a high-violence displacement environment are most destabilizing where stayees experienced comparatively low wartime violence, while this relationship is much weaker where returnees' and stayees' wartime exposure is more closely aligned.

Column 2 provides evidence for H3. Returns from comparatively more secure host countries are associated with lower levels of communal violence in settlements that were not occupied by ISIS, while the interaction with ISIS occupation is positive and statistically significant. In other words, the conflict-reducing association of return from lower-violence displacement environments weakens as stayees' wartime exposure increases. This is consistent with the argument that asymmetric exposure in which stayees endured substantially greater wartime violence can harden the returnee–stayee divide and increase the risk of communal conflict.

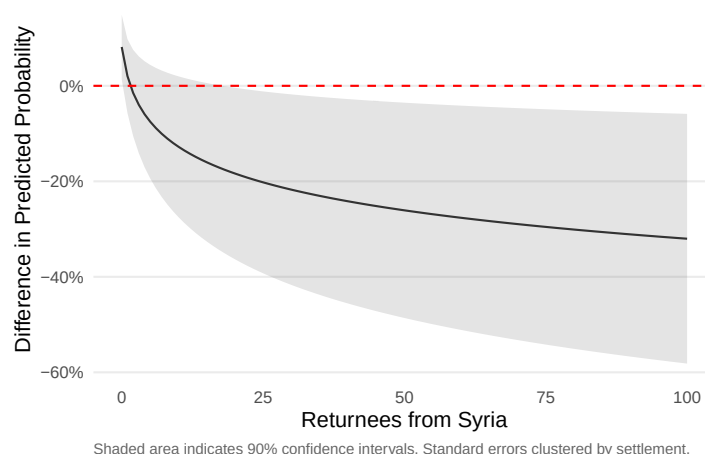


Figure 5: Mitigating Effect of Exposure to ISIS Occupation

The conditional relationships remain similar when both return measures are included simultaneously, when the full set of controls and a lagged dependent variable are added, and when the sample is restricted to settlements that hosted refugee returnees in at least one survey round (Columns 3–6). Figure 5 illustrates the substantive magnitude of the Syrian-return interaction. At 100 Syrian returnees—roughly 10% of the average settlement population—the predicted probability of communal violence is approximately 32 percentage points lower in previously ISIS-occupied settlements than in settlements without prior ISIS occupation.²¹

Columns 7–8 address endogenous return using the shift–share instruments. The interaction between

²¹Figure 5 is based on Column 6 of Table 2.

returns from Syria and prior ISIS occupation remains negative and statistically significant in both IV specifications, while the coefficient on Syrian returns remains positive. The IV results therefore reinforce the central conditional finding: returns from a high-violence displacement environment increase conflict risk where stayees experienced comparatively little wartime violence, but this destabilizing effect is substantially reduced where stayees also experienced high wartime exposure. The evidence for H3 is less consistent. The interaction between returns from other host countries and ISIS occupation is positive and statistically significant in the full-sample IV specification (Column 7), but smaller and not statistically significant in the restricted sample (Column 8).²²

The binary measure of ISIS occupation does not capture variation in the intensity of stayees' wartime exposure. I therefore examine whether the conditional relationships vary with the duration of ISIS control. Figure 6 plots the marginal effect of refugee return as the number of months under ISIS occupation increases, using the IV specification.²³ The pattern for returns from Syria is monotonic: their estimated effect on communal violence declines as the duration of ISIS occupation increases, moving from positive in communities with little or no prior ISIS exposure to negative in communities subjected to prolonged occupation. Returns from other host countries exhibit the opposite pattern, with their estimated effect becoming less negative and eventually positive as the duration of ISIS occupation increases. These patterns are consistent with the argument that the consequences of return depend on the alignment between returnees' and stayees' wartime exposure, rather than simply on whether a community experienced conflict.

Mechanism: Security Concerns and Discrimination

The ILA surveys provide suggestive evidence on two mechanisms that may connect the alignment of wartime exposure to post-return relations: perceived security threat and the hardening or softening of social boundaries.²⁴ Across survey rounds, IOM informants reported residents' general security concerns on three-point ordinal scales, including concerns about (i) ISIS-related violence and (ii) clashes between armed groups and security forces. Returnee informants also reported whether returnees experienced dis-

²²The Sargan tests do not reject the overidentifying restrictions in either IV specification ($p = 0.35$ and $p = 0.725$). First-stage estimates are reported in Supplementary Tables A12 (Column 6) and A11 (Column 7), showing large cluster-robust first-stage Wald F-statistics (48.3 to 237.9), mitigating concerns about weak instruments across the endogenous variables.

²³See Appendix Section A.19 for the corresponding estimates and additional continuous measures of wartime exposure.

²⁴The ILA measures do not directly capture empathy or recognition of shared suffering. Rather, security concerns and discrimination provide observable implications of the proposed mechanisms of threat perception and boundary hardening or softening.

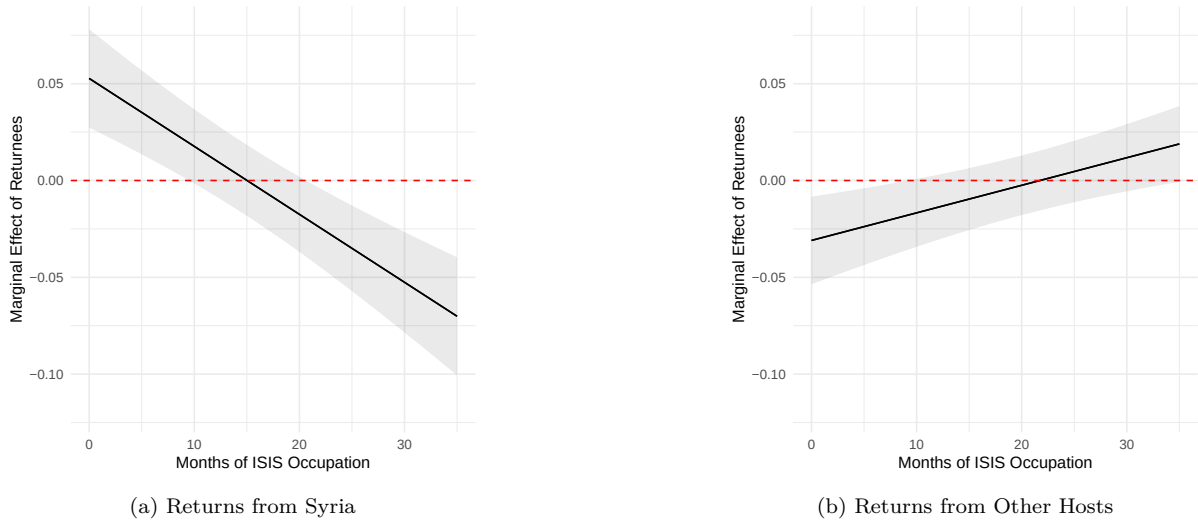


Figure 6: Marginal Effect of Refugee Returns by Duration of ISIS Occupation

crimination in access to public goods and aid, housing rental, and employment, with each item measured as a binary indicator. Using inverse-correlation weighting and standardizing each measure between 0 and 1, I construct two summary indices: one capturing security concerns among residents of assessed settlements and another capturing discrimination against returnees in settlements that had previously received returnees.

Table 3 re-estimates the main specifications using the security-concern index (Columns 1–4) and discrimination index (Columns 5–6). For returns from Syria, the interaction with prior ISIS occupation is consistently negative across both outcomes and across OLS and instrumental-variable specifications. Syrian return is therefore associated with lower security concerns and less discrimination in communities where stayees also experienced ISIS occupation than in communities without prior ISIS occupation. These patterns are consistent with H1: when returnees’ and stayees’ wartime exposure is more closely aligned, return appears less likely to be associated with perceptions of insecurity and with exclusion of returnees.

Returns from comparatively more secure host countries produce a different pattern. Their interaction with ISIS occupation is negative for security concerns, suggesting that prior ISIS exposure is not associated with greater general security concerns following these returns. By contrast, the interaction is positive and statistically significant for discrimination against returnees in both specifications. Thus, the relationship between return from comparatively more secure host countries and discrimination becomes more positive where stayees experienced ISIS occupation. This pattern is consistent with H3: when stay-

ees experienced substantial wartime violence but returnees came from comparatively safer displacement environments, the returnee–stayee boundary may harden even in the absence of heightened concerns about renewed armed violence.

	Security concern				Discrimination	
	OLS	IV	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Syria Return (Logged)	0.001 (0.002)	−0.013 (0.011)	−0.001 (0.005)	−0.005 (0.016)	−0.002 (0.003)	0.002 (0.008)
Other Return (Logged)	0.001 (0.001)	0.003 (0.002)	0.003 (0.003)	0.026*** (0.009)	−0.002* (0.001)	−0.010* (0.005)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	−0.041*** (0.009)	−0.059*** (0.016)	−0.037*** (0.011)	−0.073*** (0.023)	−0.017** (0.008)	−0.021* (0.012)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	−0.007* (0.004)	−0.009** (0.005)	−0.005 (0.009)	−0.041** (0.017)	0.016** (0.007)	0.023** (0.012)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics		4.058 (p = 0.131)		0.503 (p = 0.778)		3.379 (p = 0.185)
Num. obs.	12080	12080	1768	1768	1768	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Note. The unit of analysis is governorate-settlement-round. All models include settlement and governorate-by-round fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the settlement level.

Table 3: Refugee Return, Security Concerns, and Discrimination
(ILA Survey)

Robustness and Alternative Explanations

I conduct a series of additional analyses to assess the robustness of the main findings. First, the results are similar under alternative model specifications, including standard errors clustered at the district level, population-weighted models, and specifications that replace time-varying covariates with first-round covariate values interacted with survey-round indicators (Supplementary Tables A8 and A5). The population-weighted models assess whether the results are sensitive to giving larger settlements greater influence, while the latter specifications reduce concerns about conditioning on covariates that may themselves respond to refugee return. Second, the results are robust to alternative outcome measures, including ILA survey reports of communal violence (Appendix Section A.6) and ACLED measures of riots and violent demonstrations and of conflict events without state actors (Supplementary Figure A4). Third, the main pattern persists when I use sub-districts as the unit of analysis and when I restrict ACLED events to a 2.5-kilometer radius around each settlement (Supplementary Tables A9 and A13).

The results are also robust to alternative shift–share instruments based on different host-country shocks (Supplementary Table A10), additional controls (Supplementary Table A20), and continuous measures of stayees’ wartime exposure based on ISIS-related civilian fatalities and the duration of ISIS

occupation (Appendix Section A.19). A spatial placebo test randomly reassigns ISIS-occupation status across settlements 2,000 times. The observed Syria-return $\times$ ISIS-occupation interaction lies in the extreme tail of the resulting placebo distribution ($p < 0.001$), making it unlikely that the main result reflects random spatial overlap between return patterns and ISIS exposure. Finally, the results are similar when the sample is divided between urban and rural settlements (Supplementary Figure A12).

As an alternative identification strategy, I also estimate a triple-differences (DDD) specification using settlement-year data from 2017 to 2022. The design compares changes in communal violence following the first recorded refugee return across settlements that were and were not previously occupied by ISIS, separately for returns from Syria and from other host countries. The outcome is the same SCAD-based measure of communal violence constructed from ACLED events, while return is measured using a binary indicator derived from the ILA and IOM field reports. Appendix Section A.18 reports the corresponding event-study estimates and DDD models. The Syria-return $\times$ ISIS-occupation interaction is consistently negative across specifications, closely matching the conditional pattern in the main analysis.

Finally, I consider several alternative explanations for the conditional relationship between returns from Syria and prior ISIS occupation. One possibility is that former host country captures socioeconomic selection or differences in migration and return routes rather than wartime exposure. Refugees with greater resources may be more likely to reach European destinations and to return by air, whereas refugees in neighboring countries are more likely to return over land. Relatedly, returnees from wealthier host countries may receive more financial support, or may simply be perceived as wealthier, potentially increasing their exposure to extortion or other forms of economically motivated violence (IOM, 2023). A third possibility is strategic resource allocation: governments or aid providers may direct additional services and infrastructure toward ISIS-affected communities receiving returnees because these areas are considered particularly vulnerable to renewed conflict.

I probe the first two explanations with a placebo comparison that excludes returnees from Syria and compares returns from European countries with returns from Iraq’s neighboring states. The corresponding IV estimates show no statistically significant difference between these groups (Supplementary Figure A5), suggesting that differences in migration routes or host-country affluence alone are unlikely to account for the main conditional pattern. I examine the resource-allocation explanation directly using ILA measures of public services and local infrastructure. Rather than receiving greater post-return pro-

vision, ISIS-occupied settlements receiving returnees from Syria exhibit lower service provision, providing little support for the argument that targeted investment generates the conflict-mitigating result (Supplementary Table A15). Taken together, these analyses reduce concerns that return logistics, host-country affluence, or strategic post-return resource allocation account for the main findings.

Conditional Effects of Identity Context and Local Institutions

The conflict-mitigating effects of shared wartime exposure may depend on the social and institutional context in which return takes place. I consider two potential sources of heterogeneity. The first is local identity context: whether returnees and stayees are likely to share a salient ethnic or sectarian identity that can facilitate recognition of one another's wartime experiences. The second is the presence of legal and administrative institutions that can resolve the disputes over rights, resources, and belonging that often accompany return.

Existing studies offer competing expectations about whether identity boundaries constrain the effects of shared wartime exposure. One perspective suggests that recognition and empathy should be easier when groups share salient identities, norms, and social ties (Tellez & Balcells, 2025; Bernhard et al., 2006). Salient divisions between returnees and stayees may instead impede recognition of others' suffering and sustain intergroup distance (Fisk, 2019; Cikara et al., 2014). A second perspective, however, suggests that empathy arising from wartime suffering and identity recategorization can extend across preexisting group boundaries (Hong et al., 2020; Hartman & Morse, 2020). Recognizing that members of another group have also suffered can reduce social distance and create minimal trust for coexistence (Chew & Jap, 2025; Ayoub et al., 2024). The first perspective therefore predicts a stronger conflict-mitigating effect where returnees and stayees share a salient identity, whereas the second implies that shared exposure may reduce conflict even where such identity overlap is absent.

Legal institutions may constitute a second source of heterogeneity. Even when shared exposure reduces social distance or perceived threat, peaceful reintegration may depend on institutions capable of resolving the concrete disputes that accompany return. Courts, documentation offices, and programs addressing housing, land, and property claims can clarify rights and mediate disputes over resources and belonging (Weber & Hartman, 2022; Blattman et al., 2014). Where institutions are weak or exclusionary—for example, when returnees face barriers to documentation or have limited means of resolving

housing, land, and property claims—outsider status can harden and return-related disputes become more difficult to resolve.

	Shared Identity		Legal Institution	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.028 (0.057)	0.098 (0.077)	−0.836** (0.422)	−0.819* (0.465)
Other Return (Logged)	−0.062*** (0.019)	−0.066** (0.033)	−0.054*** (0.018)	−0.061* (0.034)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	−0.028 (0.057)	−0.135* (0.077)	0.920** (0.424)	0.824* (0.470)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.070*** (0.020)	0.042 (0.030)	0.061*** (0.019)	0.031 (0.030)
Syria Return (Logged) x Sunni Community	0.281** (0.133)	0.156 (0.132)		
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation x Sunni Community	−0.267** (0.133)	−0.139 (0.130)		
Syria Return (Logged) x Legal Institution			0.813* (0.449)	0.847 (0.518)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation x Legal Institution			−0.903** (0.451)	−0.898* (0.524)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics	2.895 (p = 0.235)	1.693 (p = 0.429)	2.848 (p = 0.241)	1.837 (p = 0.399)
Num. obs.	12080	1768	12080	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Note. The unit of analysis is governorate-settlement-round. All models include settlement and governorate-by-round fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the settlement level

Table 4: Identity Context, Legal Institutions, and the Conditional Effect of Refugee Return

Columns 1–2 of Table 4 examine heterogeneity by local identity context. I use Sunni dominance in receiving communities, based on geocoded maps from the Gulf 2000 Project, as a proxy for the likelihood of sectarian overlap between returnees from Syria and local residents.²⁵ The ILA does not report the sectarian composition of returnees themselves, so this measure cannot identify actual returnee–stayee identity matches. It nevertheless provides a rough proxy because a substantial majority of registered Iraqi refugees in Syria were Sunni.²⁶

The results provide mixed evidence that identity overlap conditions the effect of shared exposure. In the full sample (Column 1), the interaction among returns from Syria, prior ISIS occupation, and Sunni dominance is negative and statistically significant, consistent with a stronger conflict-mitigating effect of shared exposure in Sunni-dominant communities. This suggests that in post-ISIS Iraq, where intergroup boundaries were hardened by wartime violence and subsequent communal clashes, the pacifying effect of shared exposure may be stronger when returnees and stayees also share a sectarian identity. However,

²⁵All columns re-estimate the IV specification from Table 2.

²⁶UNHCR estimates that more than 63% of registered Iraqi refugees in Syria were Sunni (CRS, 2009, p. 17).

this pattern changes in the restricted sample of settlements that hosted returnees in at least one survey round (Column 2), where the effect of shared exposure appears to operate regardless of sectarian overlap. While the full-sample results provide some evidence that shared identity may facilitate the conflict-mitigating effect of common wartime experiences, the sensitivity of this relationship to the comparison group suggests that identity overlap may be less important in communities that have ever hosted refugee returnees.

Columns 3–4 examine whether the same conditional relationship varies with local legal institutions. I focus on three institutional features directly relevant to reintegration: local courts that adjudicate disputes, the Civil Affairs Directorate, which facilitates documentation, and legal programs addressing housing, land, and property (HLP) disputes. I construct a binary indicator distinguishing communities with above-average presence of these institutional features. The three-way interaction between returns from Syria, prior ISIS occupation, and legal-institutional presence is negative in both the full and restricted samples. This pattern indicates that the relationship between shared wartime exposure and lower communal violence is more pronounced where institutions capable of addressing return-related disputes are more prevalent. Unlike the identity results, this institutional heterogeneity is evident across both samples.²⁷

Conclusion

Why do some communities experience heightened communal violence when refugees return home, while others remain relatively peaceful? This paper argues that the answer depends partly on how the wartime experiences of returnees and stayees align. When both groups have experienced substantial wartime violence, recognition of shared suffering can foster empathy and soften the social boundary between those who fled and those who remained. When their experiences are asymmetric, return may instead generate perceived security threats or resentment over unequal wartime sacrifice. The central implication is that the consequences of wartime violence are relational: what violence means for post-conflict social order depends not only on what each group experienced, but also on how those experiences compare.

I evaluate this argument using settlement-level data on refugee return and communal violence in post-ISIS Iraq. Returns from conflict-affected Syria increase communal violence in communities that

²⁷Appendix Section A.14 examines the individual institutional components and shows that the main conditional pattern is also present when the analysis is restricted to settlements with these institutional features.

experienced comparatively little ISIS violence, but this destabilizing effect is substantially reduced where stayees also experienced ISIS occupation. Returns from comparatively more secure host countries exhibit the opposite conditional pattern, becoming more destabilizing as stayees' wartime exposure increases. These patterns persist across alternative specifications, measures of communal violence and wartime exposure, and an instrumental-variable strategy that exploits host-country shocks to refugee return. Together, the findings show that refugee return is neither inherently stabilizing nor destabilizing. Its consequences depend in part on the relationship between the wartime experiences of returning and receiving populations.

These findings contribute to a growing literature on the consequences of refugee return (Schwartz, 2019; Ruiz & Vargas-Silva, 2022; De Berry & Roberts, 2018; Alrababa'h et al., 2021). Much existing work highlights the risks of renewed tensions through identity cleavages (Schwartz, 2019), resource competition (Schwartz, 2019; Ruiz & Vargas-Silva, 2022), cultural friction (Alrababa'h et al., 2021), or opportunism (Blair & Wright, 2022). Yet these pressures do not produce the same consequences everywhere. By bringing returnees' displacement experiences into relation with stayees' wartime experiences, this study shows that shared suffering can operate as a social equalizer: mismatched experiences may deepen mistrust and exclusion, while common exposure to violence can foster empathy, soften group divisions, and support peaceful reintegration. The effects of return therefore depend not simply on who comes back or how many people return, but also on the wartime experiences that returnees and stayees bring to their renewed interaction.

The study also advances research on the social legacies of wartime violence. Prior work shows that exposure to violence can, under some conditions, reduce prejudice and encourage integration (Hong et al., 2020; Ghosn et al., 2019; Dinas et al., 2021a; Hartman & Morse, 2020; Chew & Jap, 2025; Ayoub et al., 2024; Dinas et al., 2021b; Whitt et al., 2025). The evidence from Iraq demonstrates that these legacies also shape relations between populations reunited after displacement. The mechanism analyses provide direct evidence that shared exposure is associated with lower security concerns and less discrimination against returnees, patterns consistent with empathy and identity recategorization. The identity analysis further suggests that these conflict-mitigating effects can extend across sectarian boundaries, while the institutional results show that they are more pronounced where legal institutions can adjudicate land disputes and facilitate returnee documentation. Shared suffering therefore does not

operate independently of the post-conflict environment: institutions can help translate greater social acceptance into more stable coexistence.

Building on these findings, a preregistered conjoint survey experiment in Ethiopia, described in Appendix Section B, extends the analysis from contextual exposure to individual wartime experiences. Among communities affected by the Tigray War, the experiment examines whether respondents react differently to returnees who experienced violence during displacement depending on their own wartime exposure, and whether perceived shared suffering increases acceptance, reduces perceived threat, and softens social boundaries. By directly measuring recognition of shared suffering, empathy, and identity boundaries in a distinct conflict setting, the experiment provides a complementary test of the individual-level processes that the settlement-level evidence from Iraq cannot directly observe.

More broadly, refugee return does not simply bring displaced people back to a place. It brings together populations whose trajectories through war may have been profoundly different. Policies centered only on material resources, property restitution, or the number of people returning may therefore miss an important dimension of reintegration: how returnees and stayees understand one another's wartime experiences. At the same time, shared suffering alone may not be enough to resolve the concrete disputes that accompany return. Institutions that clarify rights, facilitate documentation, and adjudicate property claims can help convert greater social acceptance into durable coexistence. Post-conflict order therefore depends not only on how much violence societies have endured, but also on whether the groups that must live together after war experienced that violence in similar or different ways.

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A Appendix: Iraq Analysis

A.1 Descriptive Statistics

Var	Min	Max	Mean	Std_Dev	N
Round					4
Settlements					3020
Communal Violence (ACLED)	0.000	1.000	0.343	0.475	12080
Communal Violence (ILA)	0.000	1.000	0.014	0.118	12080
Communal Violence (ACLED, lag = 1)	0.000	1.000	0.349	0.477	12080
Communal Violence (ILA, lag = 1)	0.000	1.000	0.016	0.127	9060
Returnees from Syria (logged)	0.000	6.680	0.026	0.286	12080
Returnees from Other Hosts (logged)	0.000	6.804	0.108	0.538	12080
ISIS Occupation	0.000	1.000	0.551	0.497	12080
IDPs (logged)	0.000	8.380	2.073	1.986	12080
IDP Returnees (logged)	0.000	8.883	2.827	2.808	12080
Institution Inclusiveness	0.000	1.000	0.656	0.281	12080
Public Services	0.000	1.000	0.913	0.163	12080
Night-time Light	0.000	798.425	16.215	23.043	12080
Rural Area	0.000	1.000	0.461	0.499	12080
Peri-Urban Area	0.000	1.000	0.031	0.173	12080
Repression	0.000	1.000	0.116	0.320	12080
Armed Conflict	0.000	1.000	0.207	0.405	12080
Host Instability (Syria, in 1000)	9.871	18.993	14.603	4.244	12080
EU Recog. Rate	0.320	0.420	0.368	0.040	12080
Turkey Res. Permit (in 1000)	104.444	163.955	131.363	23.219	12080

Table A1: Descriptive Statistics (Full Sample)

Var	Min	Max	Mean	Std_Dev	N
Round					4
Settlements					445
Communal Violence (ACLED)	0.000	1.000	0.450	0.498	1780
Communal Violence (ILA)	0.000	1.000	0.009	0.094	1780
Communal Violence (ACLED, lag = 1)	0.000	1.000	0.402	0.490	1780
Communal Violence (ILA, lag = 1)	0.000	1.000	0.010	0.098	1335
Returnees from Syria (logged)	0.000	6.680	0.176	0.726	1780
Returnees from Other Hosts (logged)	0.000	6.804	0.734	1.226	1780
ISIS Occupation	0.000	1.000	0.292	0.455	1780
IDPs (logged)	0.000	7.366	3.000	1.609	1780
IDP Returnees (logged)	0.000	8.634	1.734	2.798	1780
Institution Inclusiveness	0.000	1.000	0.705	0.251	1780
Public Services	0.000	1.000	0.948	0.118	1780
Night-time Light	0.017	111.191	24.142	22.077	1780
Rural Area	0.000	1.000	0.157	0.364	1780
Peri-Urban Area	0.000	1.000	0.037	0.189	1780
Repression	0.000	1.000	0.264	0.441	1780
Armed Conflict	0.000	1.000	0.103	0.304	1780
Host Instability (Syria, in 1000)	9.871	18.993	14.603	4.245	1780
EU Recog. Rate	0.320	0.420	0.368	0.040	1780
Turkey Res. Permit (in 1000)	104.444	163.955	131.363	23.225	1780

Table A2: Descriptive Statistics (Restricted Sample)

A.2 Temporal Trends of Returned Refugees in Iraq

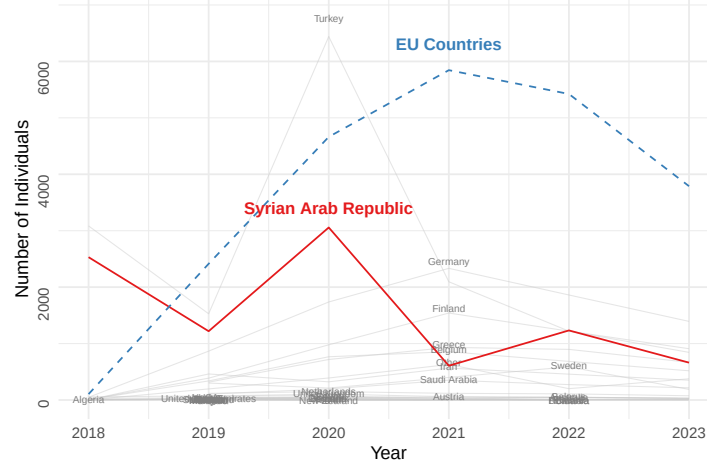


Figure A1: Trend of Refugee Returns by Migration Countries

A.3 Iraqi Refugees in Syria

The main analysis relies on returnees from Syria to measure returnees' exposure to violence during displacement. A remaining concern is whether Iraqi refugees in Syria were settled in war-affected regions or comparatively safe locations. To assess what Iraqi refugees experienced during the Syrian civil war, I draw on multiple field reports and maps from Brookings and UNHCR to identify the GADM ADM2 locations of Iraqi refugee settlements in Syria and match these locations to UCDP conflict events from 2011 to 2024. This coding captures both earlier waves of Iraqi refugees fleeing sectarian violence who were concentrated in western Syrian cities such as Damascus and Aleppo, and later Iraqi and Yazidi refugees concentrated along Syria's northeastern border after the rise of ISIS. Table A3 reports the coded locations and source materials.

Figure A3 visualizes locations with Iraqi refugee presence and civil conflict events in Syria after 2011, separating ISIS-related violence from non-ISIS conflict between other insurgent groups and the Syrian

government. From 2011 to 2024, most Iraqi refugee locations along the Syria–Iraq border experienced intense ISIS-related violence, especially those in Deir ez-Zor. At the same time, earlier Iraqi refugees concentrated in Damascus and Aleppo were exposed to even more intense violence between anti-government forces and the Assad regime during the civil war. The correspondence between refugee-settlement locations and conflict patterns confirms that Iraqi refugees in Syria were exposed to substantial wartime violence, much like stayees in ISIS-controlled territories.

These differences are further supported by difference-in-means estimates using two-sample t-tests between Syrian districts with and without recorded Iraqi refugee presence. Figure A2 shows that Iraqi refugees were located in districts that experienced at least as much violence as non-hosting districts. In particular, districts with recorded Iraqi refugee presence experienced about 0.6 standard deviations more ISIS-related conflict events, a difference that is statistically significant at the 10% level.

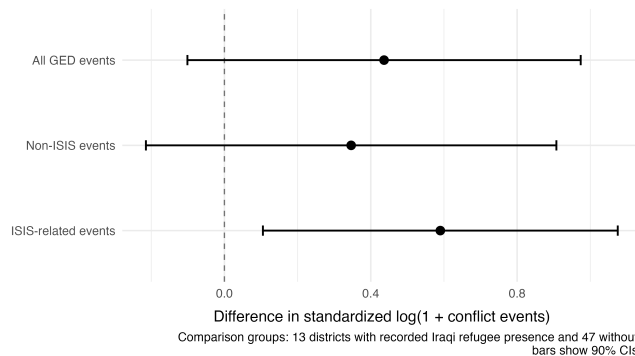


Figure A2: Violence Exposure in Syrian Districts With and Without Iraqi Refugee Presence

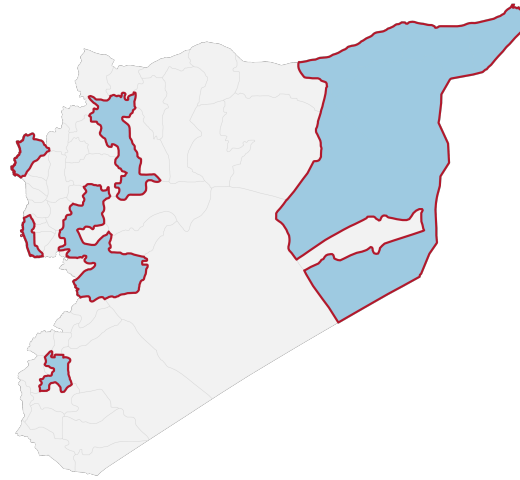
Table A3: Recorded Iraqi Presence in Syria after 2010

GADM ADM2	Basis for Coding	Source
Damascus	Urban Iraqi refugee concentration, including Yarmouk and southern Damascus	(United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2011; Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Markaz Rif Dimashq	Greater Damascus/Rural Damascus Iraqi refugee belt, including Jaramana and Sayida Zaynab	(United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2011; Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Jabal Sam'an (Aleppo)	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in the Aleppo urban area	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Hims	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in the Hims urban area	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Hama	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in the Hama urban area	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Latakia	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in the Latakia urban area	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Tartus	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in the Tartus urban area	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Deir ez-Zor	Reported Iraqi refugee presence in eastern Syria	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Abu Kamal	Reported Iraqi refugee presence near the Iraqi border	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007)
Al-Hasakah	Early Iraqi presence; later Al-Hol camp and Iraqi arrivals from Mosul	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007; United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2016; United Nations Children's Fund, 2024)
Al-Malikiyah	Newroz camp in the Malkia area and Roj camp in northern Hasakah	(United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2015, 2014a, 2016; United Nations Children's Fund, 2024)
Al Qamishli	Early Iraqi presence; later Qamishli, Amuda, Derbasiyah, and Qahtaniyah area receiving Yazidi Iraqis	(Al-Khalidi et al., 2007; United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2015, 2014b,a)
Ra's al-'Ayn	Ras al-Ain and nearby villages/towns receiving Yazidi Iraqis in 2014	(United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2014b,a)

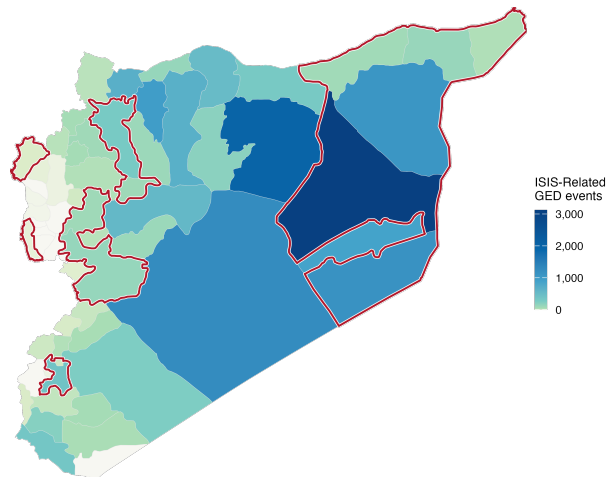
Note: The table reports GADM ADM2 units coded as having major recorded Iraqi presence after 2010. The coding is based primarily on Brookings' field report on Iraqi refugees in Syria, UNHCR's 2011 Regional Response Plan, UNHCR reporting on the Yazidi/Sinjar influx into northeast Syria, and later UNHCR and UNICEF reporting on Iraqi arrivals and camp populations in Al-Hol and Roj. Abu Kamal is coded more cautiously as a border-area extension of the eastern Syria Iraqi-presence coding.

Recorded Iraqi Presence in Syria after 2010

GADM ADM2-level coding based on UNHCR, UNICEF, and Brookings reports



ISIS-Related GED Events in Syria, 2011–2024



Non-ISIS GED Events in Syria, 2011–2024

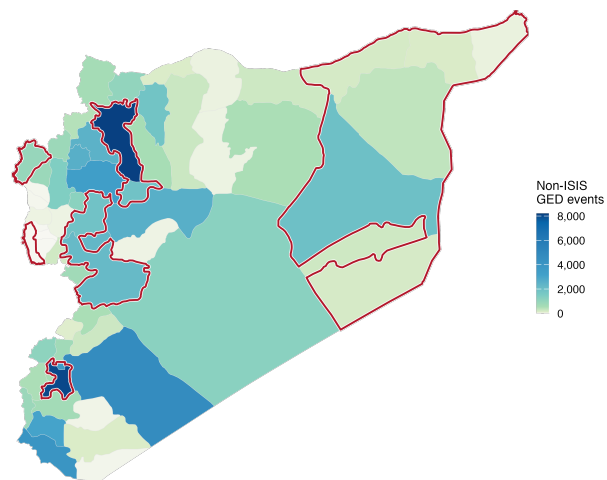


Figure A3: Iraqi Refugees and ISIS-Related Conflict Events in Syria

A.4 Regression Table with Full Covariates

	OLS						IV	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.072** (0.028)		0.091*** (0.024)	0.084*** (0.025)	0.078*** (0.024)	0.099*** (0.030)	0.149*** (0.056)	0.175** (0.070)
Other Return (Logged)		-0.050*** (0.011)	-0.053*** (0.011)	-0.049*** (0.011)	-0.054*** (0.011)	-0.034** (0.015)	-0.053*** (0.019)	-0.037 (0.030)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.066** (0.033)		-0.085*** (0.030)	-0.076** (0.030)	-0.067** (0.028)	-0.085** (0.035)	-0.156*** (0.058)	-0.204*** (0.071)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation		0.052*** (0.013)	0.054*** (0.013)	0.044*** (0.014)	0.048*** (0.014)	0.026 (0.019)	0.067*** (0.022)	0.027 (0.036)
IDPs (Logged)				0.029*** (0.009)	0.033*** (0.009)	0.008 (0.016)	0.034*** (0.009)	0.014 (0.016)
IDP Return (Logged)				-0.008 (0.021)	-0.006 (0.020)	-0.105 (0.103)	-0.004 (0.020)	-0.107 (0.099)
Night-time Light				0.002*** (0.001)	0.003*** (0.001)	-0.001 (0.002)	0.003*** (0.001)	0.002 (0.003)
Legal Institution				0.048*** (0.007)	0.043*** (0.007)	0.071*** (0.021)	0.043*** (0.007)	0.079*** (0.022)
Public Services				-0.033 (0.028)	-0.045* (0.027)	-0.128 (0.086)	-0.041 (0.027)	-0.125 (0.086)
Civil Conflict (=1)				0.046*** (0.013)	0.053*** (0.013)	0.047 (0.047)	0.051*** (0.013)	0.029 (0.046)
Lagged DV					-0.160*** (0.013)	-0.031 (0.034)	-0.160*** (0.013)	-0.030 (0.034)
Syrian Return Share							-0.065** (0.026)	-0.066** (0.032)
Other Return Share							0.030 (0.022)	0.069** (0.032)
Syrian Return Share x ISIS Occupation							-0.143*** (0.053)	-0.002 (0.057)
Other Return Share x ISIS Occupation							-0.065** (0.030)	0.002 (0.047)
Full Control				✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV					✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Full	Full	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics							1.353 (p = 0.508)	3.264 (p = 0.196)
Num. obs.	12080	12080	12080	12080	12080	1768	12080	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A4: Estimations with Full Covariates

A.5 Baseline Covariates Interacted with Survey-Round Indicators

In the main analysis, I include time-varying covariates measuring other population flows, including the numbers of IDPs and IDP returnees, as well as nighttime light intensity, insurgent activity, and summary indices of public-goods provision and local institutions in each survey round. Because some of these conditions may themselves respond to refugee return, I estimate alternative specifications that replace the contemporaneous measures with their baseline values interacted with survey-round indicators. This approach accounts for differential trends associated with preexisting settlement characteristics while avoiding direct adjustment for potentially post-treatment covariates (Caetano et al., 2022). Table A5 reports results consistent with the main analysis.

	OLS					IV		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.072** (0.028)		0.091*** (0.024)	0.092*** (0.029)	0.086*** (0.028)	0.123*** (0.036)	0.223** (0.091)	0.332*** (0.102)
Other Return (Logged)		-0.050*** (0.011)	-0.053*** (0.011)	-0.045*** (0.011)	-0.049*** (0.011)	-0.027* (0.014)	-0.055*** (0.020)	-0.021 (0.036)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.066** (0.033)		-0.085*** (0.030)	-0.088*** (0.032)	-0.077** (0.031)	-0.090** (0.039)	-0.221** (0.091)	-0.335*** (0.102)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation		0.052*** (0.013)	0.054*** (0.013)	0.030** (0.013)	0.034** (0.014)	0.044** (0.019)	0.042** (0.021)	0.017 (0.040)
Full Control				✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV					✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Full	Full	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics							2.102 (p = 0.35)	0.644 (p = 0.725)
Num. obs.	12080	12080	12080	12080	12080	1768	12080	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A5: Estimates Using Baseline Covariates Interacted with Survey-Round Indicators

A.6 Survey-Based Measures of Communal Tension and Violence

To complement the ACLED event-based measure used in the main analysis, I construct survey-based indicators of communal tension and violence within ILA-assessed settlements. In the ILA, local and returnee representatives serve as key informants and report whether hostilities or violence occurred between (1) returnees and local residents, (2) IDPs and local residents, or (3) ethnic, religious, or tribal groups within the settlement. Table A6 lists the relevant survey questions, which capture three forms of intergroup tension: (1) physical attacks, (2) threats of violence, and (3) mistrust or exclusion.

These survey measures offer two advantages. First, they can identify tensions and incidents directly involving displaced populations, which are rarely distinguished in event-based datasets. Second, they incorporate local informants' knowledge of incidents that may not be publicly reported. I code each outcome as equal to one when either a local or returnee informant reports the corresponding form of intergroup tension or violence.

The event- and survey-based measures provide complementary forms of evidence. The ACLED data offer a consistently and externally coded record of communal violence across all survey rounds from 2019 to 2022, whereas the ILA measures more directly capture local tensions involving returnees and other displaced populations. Using both sources therefore permits triangulation while mitigating the limitations associated with any single measure.

Because the survey instrument varies across waves, the disaggregated measures of physical attacks, threats, and mistrust are available only in Rounds IV and V. In Rounds VI and VII, the ILA instead asks broader questions about whether any security incidents, threats, or mistrust occurred between groups. Because these broader items do not distinguish between tensions and incidents that escalated into actual violence, they are not directly comparable to the earlier measures. I therefore restrict this analysis to Rounds IV and V and to settlements that hosted returnees in at least one survey round.

Table A7 presents OLS estimates for the three forms of communal tension and violence. The results corroborate the main ACLED-based findings: shared exposure to wartime violence is associated with lower levels of communal tension within receiving settlements. More specifically, the interaction between

Question	Outcome
In your location, have any incidents of physical violence occurred between different groups during the past three months?	Physical attacks
In your location, have any threats occurred between different groups during the past three months?	Threats
In your location, has there been any mistrust between different groups during the past three months?	Mistrust

Table A6: ILA Questions Measuring Communal Tension and Violence

returns from Syria and prior ISIS occupation is negative and statistically significant for both physical attacks and mistrust between groups. These patterns provide evidence that shared exposure mitigates actual intergroup violence and are consistent with the proposed mechanisms of reduced social distance and softened group boundaries. The interaction is not statistically significant for threats, although its direction remains consistent with the theoretical expectation.

	Physical Attack	Threat	Mistrust
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.003 (0.003)	-0.006 (0.004)	0.001 (0.005)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.004 (0.003)	-0.001 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.002)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.031* (0.017)	-0.014 (0.016)	-0.018*** (0.006)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.030 (0.018)	-0.014 (0.013)	-0.010 (0.008)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Restricted (Rounds 4-5)	Restricted (Rounds 4-5)	Restricted (Rounds 4-5)
Num. obs.	968	968	968

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Note. The unit of analysis is governorate-settlement-round. All models include settlement and governorate-by-round fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the district level.

Table A7: Shared Traumatic Experiences and ILA Assessed Communal Tensions

A.7 Alternative Model Specifications

	District Clustered SE				Population Weighted			
	OLS	IV	OLS	IV	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Syria Return (Logged)	0.086*** (0.030)	0.223*** (0.082)	0.123*** (0.043)	0.332*** (0.090)	0.118*** (0.035)	0.370*** (0.123)	0.136*** (0.045)	0.478*** (0.154)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.049*** (0.017)	-0.055 (0.035)	-0.027* (0.014)	-0.021 (0.047)	-0.012 (0.015)	0.009 (0.028)	-0.016 (0.022)	0.007 (0.060)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.077* (0.043)	-0.221** (0.085)	-0.090* (0.049)	-0.335*** (0.088)	-0.114*** (0.037)	-0.374*** (0.124)	-0.125*** (0.047)	-0.487*** (0.155)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.034* (0.020)	0.042 (0.035)	0.042* (0.023)	0.017 (0.044)	-0.017 (0.020)	-0.039 (0.030)	0.016 (0.025)	-0.021 (0.064)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Restricted	Restricted	Full	Full	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics		1.349 ($p = 0.509$)		0.557 ($p = 0.757$)		0.314 ($p = 0.989$)		4.881 ($p = 0.300$)
Num. obs.	12080	12080	1768	1768	12080	12080	1768	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A8: Estimations with Alternative Model Specifications

A.8 Sub-District Level Analysis

	OLS		IV	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.189*** (0.061)	0.188*** (0.060)	0.349* (0.204)	0.373 (0.236)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.062* (0.033)	-0.066** (0.033)	-0.065 (0.089)	-0.099 (0.105)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.183** (0.074)	-0.184** (0.070)	-0.370* (0.207)	-0.398* (0.236)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.013 (0.049)	-0.008 (0.050)	-0.004 (0.080)	-0.011 (0.085)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sub-District FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV		✓		✓
Sargan Statistics			1.903 (p = 0.386)	1.857 (p = 0.395)
Num. obs.	364	364	364	364

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Table A9: Shared Traumatic Experiences and Communal Violence
(Sub-District Level Analysis)

A.9 Alternative External Shock and Returnee Share

To ensure that the instrumental-variable estimates are not sensitive to the choice of external shocks or settlement-level returnee shares, I adopt several alternative measures of both the shift and share components. First, in Columns 1 and 2 of Table A10,²⁸ I use the timing of the 2021 ceasefire in Syria as an alternative exogenous shock that reduced Iraqi refugees' incentives to return from Syria. Second, for returns from other host countries, I use the total number of identified migrant smugglers in Turkey as an alternative shift variable (Columns 3 and 4). I also use a time-invariant measure of returnee shares from ILA Round 4, capturing the baseline shares of the earliest recorded returnees from Syria and other host countries in each settlement, as alternative share components of the IV (Columns 5 and 6). Across these specifications, the results consistently show a conflict-mitigating effect of shared traumatic experiences for both survey-based measures of communal tensions from the ILA, including physical attacks, threats, and hostile environments, and the event-based ACLED measure of communal violence.²⁹

	Post Ceasefire		Migration Smuggler in Turkey		Baseline Returnee Share	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.194*** (0.071)	0.193*** (0.075)	0.193*** (0.073)	0.145* (0.084)	0.219** (0.094)	0.163* (0.089)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.064*** (0.021)	-0.064* (0.037)	-0.060*** (0.021)	-0.150*** (0.058)	-0.050 (0.035)	0.120 (0.213)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.184*** (0.071)	-0.220*** (0.075)	-0.186** (0.073)	-0.187** (0.085)	-0.231** (0.094)	-0.159* (0.089)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.069*** (0.022)	0.032 (0.034)	0.078*** (0.028)	0.098** (0.050)	0.061* (0.035)	-0.029 (0.205)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged Conflict	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics	1.728 (p = 0.421)	0.812 (p = 0.666)	1.214 (p = 0.545)	2.412 (p = 0.299)	5.485 (p = 0.064)	2.653 (p = 0.265)
Num. obs.	12080	1768	12080	1768	12080	1768

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Table A10: Alternative External Shock

²⁸I replicate the model using the full set of controls and the lagged dependent variable.

²⁹The high Sargan statistic in Model 5 leads to rejection of the overidentifying restrictions, suggesting that the IV based on Round 4 baseline returnee shares may not be valid in the full sample. However, the Sargan test is not statistically significant in Model 6, providing greater support for the validity of this specification when the comparison group is restricted to settlements that did not initially receive returnees but received them in subsequent rounds.

A.10 First-Stage Estimations

	Returnees (Syria) (1)	Returnees (Other) (2)	Returnees (Syria) x Occupation (3)	Returnees (Other) x Occupation (4)
Ret. Share (Syria) × Conflict (Syria)	0.3776*** (0.0555)	-0.1697 (0.1040)	0.0008 (0.0015)	-0.0010 (0.0014)
Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Recognition (EU)	0.1254* (0.0664)	-21.36*** (1.070)	0.0792** (0.0392)	0.0240 (0.0367)
Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Smuggler (Turkey)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0459*** (0.0016)	0.0002** (6.73 × 10 ⁻⁵)	-1.55 × 10 ⁻⁵ (9.47 × 10 ⁻⁵)
Ret. Share (Syria) × Conflict (Syria) × ISIS Occupation	1.554*** (0.1297)	0.0827 (0.1159)	1.931*** (0.1172)	-0.0823 (0.0525)
ISIS Occupation × Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Recognition (EU)	0.2405 (1.515)	-55.73*** (4.062)	0.2364 (1.514)	-77.44*** (3.920)
ISIS Occupation × Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Smuggler (Turkey)	0.0026 (0.0036)	-0.0760*** (0.0065)	0.0022 (0.0036)	-0.1220*** (0.0063)
Ret. Share (Syria)	2.201*** (0.4312)	-0.5105 (0.9080)	0.0101* (0.0057)	0.0047 (0.0052)
Ret. Share (Other)	-0.0015 (0.0421)	15.35*** (0.6015)	-0.0493** (0.0224)	-0.0122 (0.0217)
Ret. Share (Syria) × ISIS Occupation	0.5617 (0.4835)	0.5887 (0.9152)	2.754*** (0.2192)	0.0651 (0.1161)
Ret. Share (Other) × ISIS Occupation	-0.4792 (1.053)	31.21*** (2.409)	-0.4002 (1.052)	46.71*** (2.334)
First Stage Wald F	60.753	237.91	54.793	70.902
Cragg-Donald Wald F statistic			463.7	
Settlement fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-Governorate fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Ethnic Fragmentation × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓
Urban Areas × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓
Population × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓

Table A11: First-Stage IV Estimation Results (Table 2 Column 6)

	Returnees (Syria) (1)	Returnees (Other) (2)	Returnees (Syria) x Occupation (3)	Returnees (Other) x Occupation (4)
Ret. Share (Syria) × Conflict (Syria)	0.3863*** (0.0588)	-0.1628* (0.0969)	0.0068 (0.0129)	0.0095 (0.0130)
Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Recognition (EU)	-0.8848 (0.7446)	-21.07*** (2.542)	-0.6983 (0.7220)	0.3382 (1.028)
Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Smuggler (Turkey)	-0.0039** (0.0018)	-0.0622*** (0.0049)	-0.0031* (0.0018)	-0.0008 (0.0026)
Ret. Share (Syria) × Conflict (Syria) × ISIS Occupation	1.655*** (0.1421)	-0.0505 (0.1570)	2.038*** (0.1298)	-0.2056 (0.1354)
ISIS Occupation × Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Recognition (EU)	6.069 (4.932)	-48.20*** (4.742)	5.582 (4.882)	-74.15*** (5.154)
ISIS Occupation × Ret. Share (Other) × Rfg. Smuggler (Turkey)	0.0014 (0.0083)	-0.0494*** (0.0081)	0.0001 (0.0082)	-0.1139*** (0.0081)
Ret. Share (Syria)	2.124*** (0.4339)	-0.8970 (0.9249)	0.0016 (0.0245)	0.0127 (0.0281)
Ret. Share (Other)	0.7030 (0.4519)	16.50*** (1.453)	0.5577 (0.4402)	-0.0986 (0.6311)
Ret. Share (Syria) × ISIS Occupation	0.0242 (0.4618)	1.159 (0.9357)	2.168*** (0.1608)	0.2483 (0.1797)
Ret. Share (Other) × ISIS Occupation	-2.622 (2.834)	25.90*** (2.646)	-2.271 (2.802)	44.82*** (2.863)
First Stage Wald F	52.476	108.21	48.268	89.433
Cragg-Donald Wald F statistic			48.7	
Settlement fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-Governorate fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Ethnic Fragmentation × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓
Urban Areas × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓
Population × Round	✓	✓	✓	✓

Table A12: First-Stage IV Estimation Results (Table 2 Column 7)

A.11 Alternative Measurements of the Outcome Variable

While the main analysis focuses on communal violence involving at least one organized social group, this captures only one dimension of the interactions between returnees and stayees. Post-return tensions may also manifest in less organized forms, such as violent demonstrations and riots triggered by economic disruptions associated with refugee return. Figure A4 presents the IV estimates based on the restricted sample, using alternative measures of the outcome variable: the left column displays violent demonstrations and riots, while the right column shows all conflict events that exclude any state participants. The findings indicate that shared exposure to violence significantly helps mitigate both individual-level clashes and organized armed confrontations between social groups.

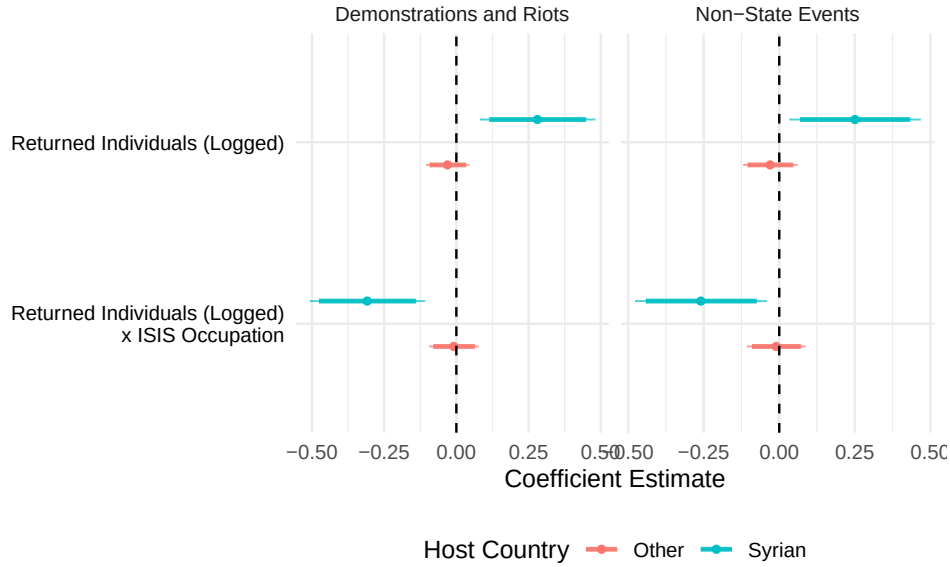


Figure A4: Alternative Measurement of Outcome Variables

A.12 Alternative Radius and Post-survey Periods

	2.5 km Radius		Post-survey period	
	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Syria Return (Logged)	0.067** (0.027)	0.198** (0.099)	0.098*** (0.029)	0.260*** (0.087)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.004 (0.012)	-0.007 (0.032)	-0.012 (0.013)	0.004 (0.032)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.055* (0.032)	-0.204** (0.100)	-0.060* (0.034)	-0.252*** (0.088)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.020 (0.020)	-0.024 (0.040)	0.018 (0.018)	-0.023 (0.036)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics		0.27 (p = 0.874)		2.626 (p = 0.269)
Num. obs.	1768	1768	1768	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A13: Shared Traumatic Experiences and Communal Violence
(Alternative Radius and Post-survey Periods)

A.13 Returnees from EU versus Non-EU Countries

In the main analysis, I assess the effect of shared exposure to violence on communal violence through an interaction term between the returnees' host country and the Islamic State (ISIS) pre-occupation status of the stayees' settlements. This strategy helps compare outcomes between returnees from Syria, where displacement often involved exposure to violence, and those from other countries. However, several alternative explanations could account for these differences.

One such explanation relates to the mode of migration and return. Refugees with greater economic resources or social networks are more likely to seek asylum in Europe rather than in neighboring countries.³⁰ Most Iraqi refugees traveling to Europe go by air, while others transit through countries like Turkey or Lebanon. In contrast, refugees heading to nearby countries such as Syria or Jordan tend to travel by land via limited border-crossing points (in yellow), often with fewer resources and shorter migration plans. These differences affect return dynamics: returnees from Syria often reenter Iraq through border crossings, whereas returnees from Europe usually fly directly to major airports. These logistical distinctions may influence reintegration by shaping how hardship is experienced during the return journey. Moreover, returnees from Europe may receive more financial support or at least be perceived as wealthier, which could increase their vulnerability to extortion or other forms of economic violence (IOM, 2023).

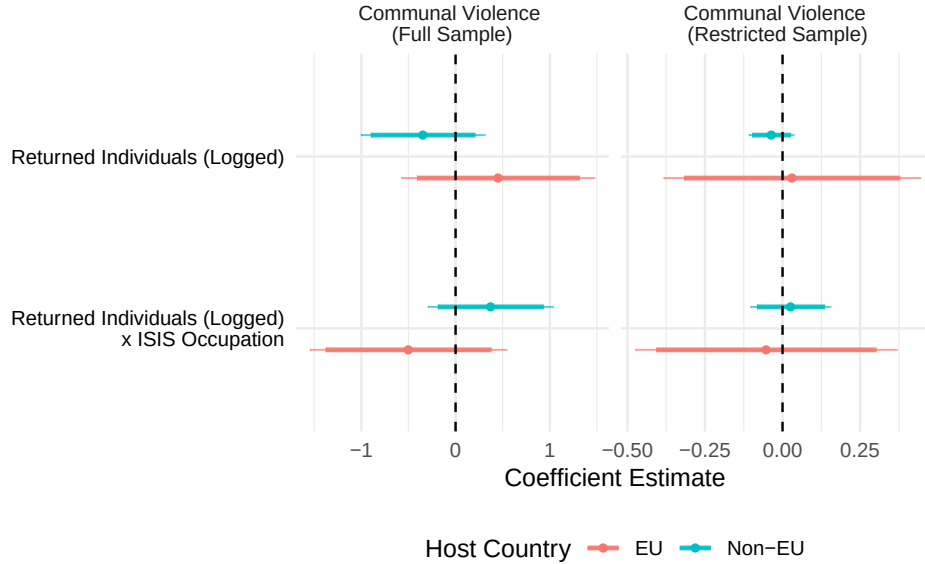


Figure A5: Returnees from EU versus Non-EU Countries

To account for these alternative explanations, I conduct a placebo analysis by excluding returnees from Syria and compare outcomes between individuals returning from Europe and those returning from Iraq's other neighbors: Jordan, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Iran. These countries are more comparable to Syria in terms of regional proximity and road-based return pathways, but unlike Syria, they did not experience widespread violence during the period of Iraqi displacement. The shift-share instrumental variable is constructed using the same approach as in the main analysis. I use the likelihood of receiving refugees returning from EU and non-EU countries as the share component. For the external shock driving returns from EU member states, I use the average EU asylum recognition rate in the year preceding each survey round. For returns from Jordan, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Iran, I use the total number of conflicts in Iraq's neighboring countries as the external shock influencing refugee return patterns.

The IV estimations in Figure A5 show no significant differences between Iraqi refugees returning from European countries and those from Iraq's neighboring states, suggesting that travel conditions or logistics alone are unlikely to explain the main findings.

³⁰This does not imply all returnees from Europe stayed long-term. For example, many Iraqi asylum seekers who migrated during the 2021 Belarus migration crisis returned quickly due to limited rights and economic opportunities in host countries (IOM, 2024).

A.14 Settlements with Inclusive Institutions

Figure A6 shows the distribution of three types of inclusive institutions for which data are available: local courts that adjudicate general disputes, legal programs addressing land and property conflicts between returnees and stayees, and the Civil Affairs Directorate, which facilitates documentation for returnees. Communities that have ever received refugee returns tend to exhibit a higher prevalence of such institutions, and the vast majority (92–95%) maintain at least one, suggesting broad local support for post-return reintegration. Table A14 further shows that the effect of shared suffering on communal violence is even stronger in the presence of any inclusive institution.

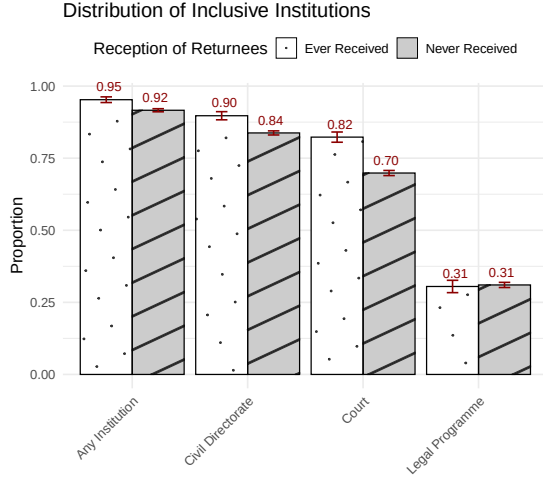


Figure A6: Distribution of Inclusive Institutions

	Any (1)	Court (2)	Civil Dir. (3)	Legal Prog. (4)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.438** (0.212)	0.463* (0.243)	0.442** (0.212)	0.525 (0.454)
Non-Syria Return (Logged)	-0.064 (0.051)	-0.066 (0.056)	-0.063 (0.052)	-0.207 (0.164)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.448** (0.210)	-0.467* (0.241)	-0.452** (0.210)	0.545 (1.489)
No-Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.037 (0.049)	0.044 (0.056)	0.039 (0.049)	-0.618 (0.948)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged Conflict	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics	3.434 (p = 0.18)	3.728 (p = 0.155)	3.802 (p = 0.149)	0.015 (p = 0.992)
Num. obs.	1265	1159	1253	263

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Table A14: Settlements with Inclusive Institutions

A.15 Post-return Resource Distribution

One alternative explanation for why returnees from Syria reintegrate more peacefully in ISIS-occupied areas is that the government may direct additional resources to returnee-hosting locations that are especially sensitive to security concerns. Areas that both experienced ISIS occupation and received returnees from Syria may be viewed as particularly vulnerable to ISIS remnants or renewed civil conflict, prompting the government to increase investment in public services and infrastructure to win local support and raise the opportunity cost of communal violence.

Table A15 reports IV estimates of the effects of refugee returns on local infrastructure and public services at the settlement-round level. These results help rule out the possibility that the main findings simply reflect post-return resource allocation. Column 1 uses the ICW summary index, constructed from several ILA indicators, and shows that refugee returns from Syria increase public services and infrastructure investment in areas never occupied by ISIS but significantly reduce overall provision in ISIS-occupied areas. Rather than strategic resource targeting, this pattern suggests a shortage of public resources caused by population shocks—an effect that should heighten, not dampen, communal violence (Schwartz, 2019). Columns 2–6 examine each indicator separately and show that the interaction term is either null or significantly negative.

Together, these findings indicate that the main results are unlikely to be driven by post-return resource distribution, reinforcing the interpretation that mutual empathy and identity re-categorization underlie the pacifying effect of refugee return.

A.16 Limitations of the IOM ILA Survey Data

The ILA data present three main limitations. First, coverage is access-driven: surveyed communities depend on IOM's ability to reach them, which could bias the sample if the most insecure areas are excluded. In practice, this bias appears limited. In Round 4, for instance, only 45 of 3,645 planned communities denied field access, and most of those were surveyed remotely by phone. To mitigate this concern, I retain the community as the unit of analysis rather than aggregating to higher administrative levels, thereby reducing measurement error and preserving internal validity. Although this choice

	Summary Index		Binary Indicator			
	Services	Market	Electricity	Water	Health	Education
Syria Return (Logged)	0.087*	0.318***	0.087	0.025	0.159**	0.084
	(0.047)	(0.099)	(0.064)	(0.056)	(0.074)	(0.075)
Non-Syria Return (Logged)	-0.007	0.016	0.002	-0.013	-0.036*	-0.015
	(0.008)	(0.020)	(0.009)	(0.010)	(0.022)	(0.014)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.083*	-0.317***	-0.066	-0.013	-0.187**	-0.093
	(0.047)	(0.100)	(0.065)	(0.059)	(0.075)	(0.076)
No-Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.003	0.007	-0.005	0.006	0.051**	0.010
	(0.007)	(0.021)	(0.010)	(0.016)	(0.020)	(0.010)
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged Conflict	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics	0.365	2.689	0.58	1.853	1.084	0.37
	(p = 0.833)	(p = 0.261)	(p = 0.748)	(p = 0.396)	(p = 0.581)	(p = 0.831)
Num. obs.	1768	1768	1768	1768	1768	1768

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A15: Refugee Return, ISIS Occupation and the Governmental Provision of Public Services

may reduce representativeness, it yields analytically valuable insights for contexts where return is most feasible—since refugees rarely return to active war zones. The sample also excludes Al-Jaddah-1 Camp, which receives returnees from Syria’s Al-Hawl camp. Because these returnees are screened and isolated from local residents, omitting this site likely biases estimates downward: According to figure A7, reported incidents of communal violence within a 5-km radius of Al-Jaddah-1 are rare and disappear entirely after official repatriation.

Second, survey instruments vary across rounds: only Rounds IV and V include items explicitly referencing returnee-related communal violence, while later rounds aggregate diverse forms of tension—such as attacks, threats, or exclusion—into a single index, limiting comparability.

Third, the surveys rely on key informants who report perceived rather than directly observed incidents, raising the risk of underreporting or social desirability bias. These features make the ILA indicators a conservative measure of communal tension. Accordingly, I treat the ILA as a complementary data source and rely on event-based media reports as the primary measure of communal violence. The media data capture broader conflict dynamics across identity groups in receiving areas, while the ILA provides more localized evidence of tensions specifically between returnees and stayees.

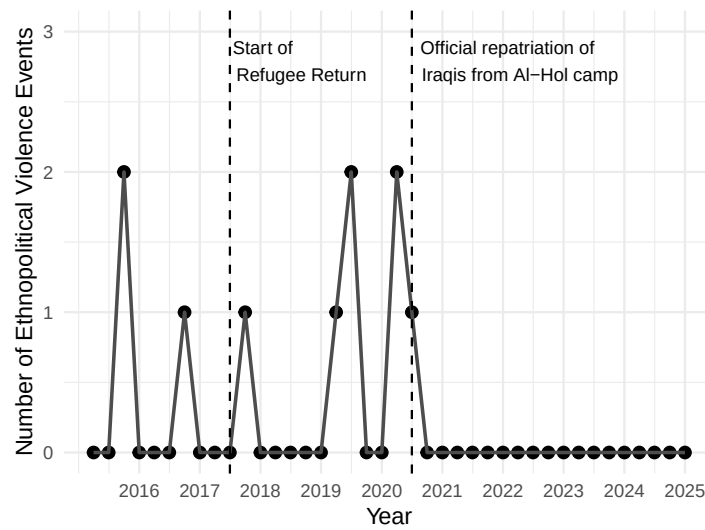


Figure A7: Communal Violence at the Al-Jaddah-1 Camp

A.17 Extra Diagnostic Tests of the Instrumental Variable

Although strong first-stage F-statistics and overidentification tests support the validity of the instrumental variable design, the exclusion restriction may still be violated if unobserved time-varying factors correlated with historical return intensity influence communal violence. I address this concern through three diagnostic tests.

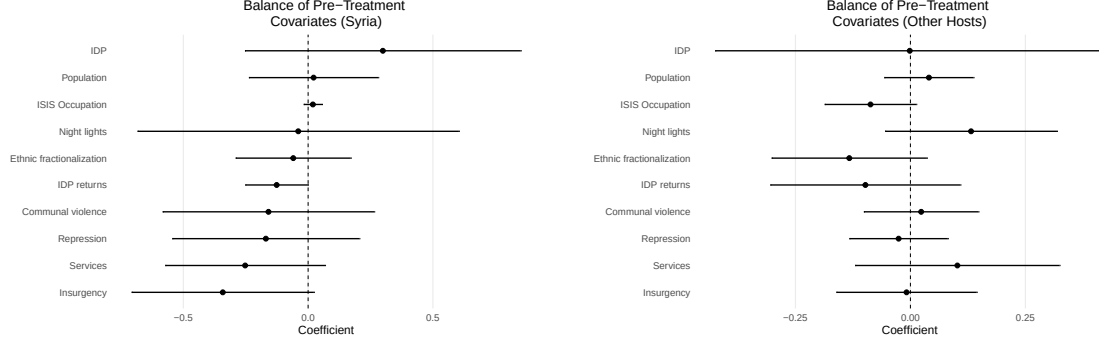


Figure A8: Balance of Pre-Treatment Variables

The first test examines covariate balance to ensure that localities with and without return are comparable on pre-treatment characteristics. Figure A8 shows that ISIS occupation is not correlated with the patterns of return. High- and low-return areas are similar across most covariates, though localities with greater return intensity tend to have higher numbers of IDP returnees. Returnees from Syria are slightly more likely to settle in areas with weaker public-goods provision, whereas returnees from other hosts cluster in less ethnically fractionalized communities. These patterns are consistent with wartime damage to home areas and subsequent settlement choices. Importantly, the Syrian pattern likely biases estimates toward greater violence, producing conservative estimates of any conflict-mitigating effect. In contrast, the pattern among returnees from other hosts likely biases estimates toward lower violence, making observed mitigation effects more readily detectable.

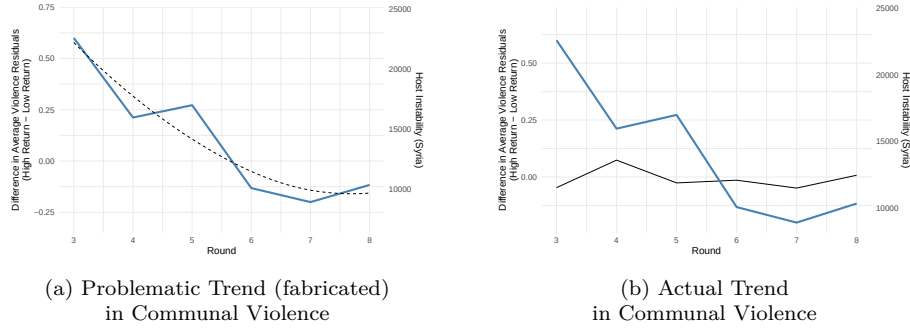


Figure A9: Trends in ACLED Communal Violence (High vs Low Returns from Syria)

The second test examines the key exogeneity assumption underlying shift-share instruments. This assumption requires that the instrument captures exogenous shocks originating from host countries rather than reflecting long-term trends in the distribution of the endogenous share variable. If the shift variable represents a one-time shock, this assumption is equivalent to the common-trend assumption in a continuous DID design, which requires that areas with low and high likelihoods of receiving returnees do not differ in their pre-treatment trends. However, because the shift variables in this paper are time-varying refugee regulations and security conditions in host countries, I apply Gehring et al. (2022)'s sensitivity test to ensure that there is no overlap between two sources of trends: 1) trends in differences in the outcome variable between areas with low and high levels of historical return and 2) trends in the external host-country shocks. Figures A9 and A10 present results for returnees from Syria and from other host countries. The trends in the High-Low returnee settlements' differences in communal violence diverge from both security conditions in Syria and refugee regulations in safer host countries such as the EU and Turkey (right panels), which rules out problematic scenarios of violation in which these trends closely align (as illustrated in the fabricated figures in the left panels).

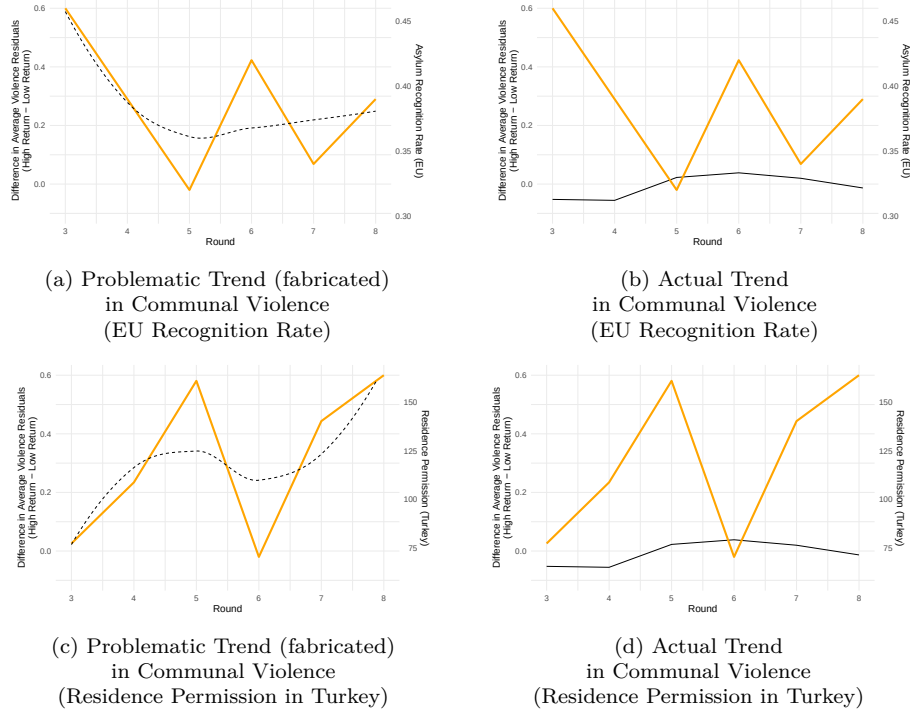


Figure A10: Trends in ACLED Communal Violence (High vs Low Returns from Other Hosts)

The third test estimates a reduced-form model of the shift-share specification, incorporating an interaction between the share component and survey round. Table A16 shows that, conditional on the full set of shift-share terms, the share-by-round interaction has no independent effect on communal violence. This result provides suggestive evidence that time-varying factors correlated with the share component do not drive the main results, supporting the validity of the exclusion restriction and strengthening confidence in the causal interpretation of the IV estimates.

	Event-based		Survey-based	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
High-Return (Syria) x Host Instability	0.140*** (0.049)	0.298** (0.117)	0.002 (0.003)	0.000 (0.002)
High-Return (Others) x Turkey Residency	-0.010*** (0.003)	0.012 (0.095)	-0.001** (0.000)	-0.001 (0.000)
High-Return (Others) x Eu Recognition	-4.094** (1.689)	3.742 (37.853)	-0.060 (0.099)	
High-Return (Syria) x Occupy x Host Instability	-0.209*** (0.061)	-0.348*** (0.123)	-0.038* (0.020)	-0.018*** (0.004)
High-Return (Others) x Occupy x Turkey Residency	0.017*** (0.004)	-0.025 (0.104)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.001* (0.000)
High-Return (Others) x Occupy x Eu Recognition	7.889*** (1.945)	-8.063 (41.902)	-0.170 (0.314)	
High-Return (Syria) x Round		0.157* (0.081)		-0.003 (0.004)
High-Return (Others) x Round		-0.284 (1.289)		-0.002 (0.004)
High-Return (Syria) x Occupy x Round		-0.138 (0.089)		0.025 (0.026)
High-Return (Others) x Occupy x Round		0.556 (1.417)		-0.007 (0.011)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓
TW FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Num. obs.	1768	1768	1326	1326

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A16: Reduced Form Estimation

A.18 Triple-differences (DDD) Design

As an additional check, I implement a triple-differences (DDD) design to address potential endogeneity. The approach compares how the effect of refugee return differs between areas with and without prior ISIS occupation. The unit of analysis is the settlement-year. I combine the ILA survey with IOM field reports to construct a binary indicator of returnee presence, while the outcome variable is SCAD-defined extragovernmental violence based on ACLED events from 2018 to 2023.³¹ Covariates include night-time lights, population, insurgency, repression, IDPs, and IDP returns. Figure A11 and Table A17 show results consistent with the main findings in both event-based and panel analyses.³²

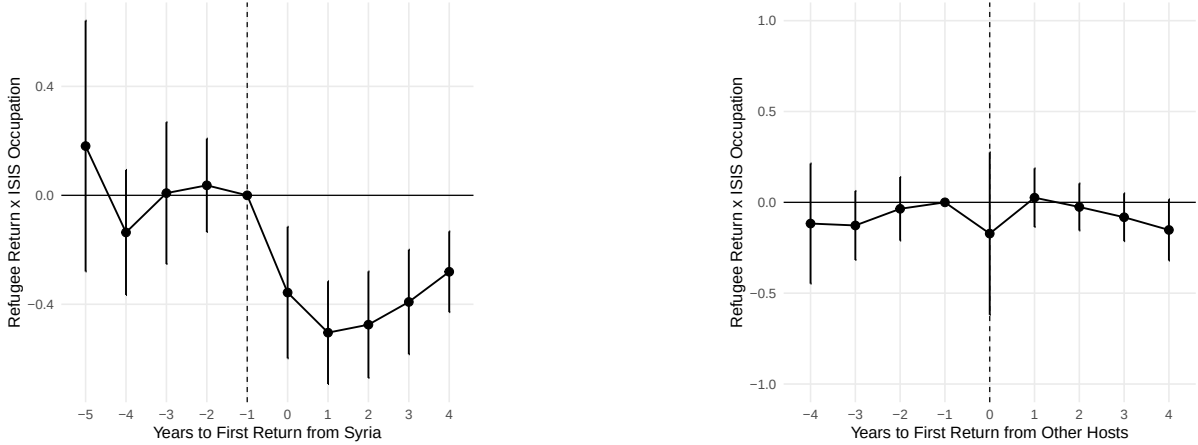


Figure A11: Event Study Approach for the DDD Estimate

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Syria Return (=1)	0.257*** (0.044)	0.259*** (0.042)	0.250*** (0.055)	0.119*** (0.029)
Other Return (=1)	-0.049 (0.046)	-0.053 (0.046)	-0.064 (0.041)	0.016 (0.031)
Syria Return (=1) x ISIS Occupation	-0.376*** (0.085)	-0.392*** (0.078)	-0.404*** (0.098)	-0.237*** (0.043)
Other Return (=1) x ISIS Occupation	-0.004 (0.074)	0.010 (0.069)	0.037 (0.067)	-0.078 (0.062)
Full Control		✓	✓	✓
Location FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Time FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Governorate by Time FE				✓
Lagged DV			✓	✓
Sample	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted	Restricted
Num. obs.	3560	3560	3115	3094

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$

Table A17: Triple-differences (DDD) Estimates

³¹The ILA survey provides clean and complete measures of refugee return only from Rounds IV (2019) through VII (2022), following the retreat of ISIS. Although Round III (2018) also includes a measure of refugee return, it does not provide full national coverage and does not distinguish between the stock of refugees who had returned before 2018 and new returnees arriving in 2018. I therefore exclude this survey round from the main analysis. In addition to the ILA survey, IOM also collected information on refugee return through its Rapid Assessment and Response Teams (RARTs), reported in the “Returnees from Abroad” datasets. These data face an important limitation: the settlements covered are not consistent across reporting months, and directly combining them with the ILA data may create problems of double-counting. I therefore do not rely on the exact number of returnees. Instead, I construct a binary indicator of whether any refugee return from Syria or other countries was reported in a given settlement-year by either data source. Given the relatively coarse nature of this measure and the possibility of missing return episodes, I use this analysis only as a robustness check rather than as part of the main empirical evidence.

³²Joint Wald tests of all interaction terms between the time-to-treatment indicators and ISIS occupation are statistically insignificant for both returns from Syria ($p = 0.16$) and returns from other host countries ($p = 0.70$).

A.19 Continuous Measure of Wartime Suffering

While the ILA surveys include questions that directly capture whether each settlement experienced ISIS occupation, a binary indicator does not reflect the intensity of wartime trauma among civilians who remained. To address this, I first use the ACLED database to measure per-capita civilian fatalities in each settlement caused by ISIS during 2016–2017 (prior to refugee return). This captures the intensity of civilian targeting during the conflict. Next, I use <https://liveuamap.com/> to measure the duration of ISIS occupation for each settlement; longer periods under ISIS control indicate greater exposure to violence. Supplementary Table A18 shows the IV estimation of conflict-mitigating effects on ACLED events for both measures, which are consistent with the main analysis.

	Months of Occupation				Civilian Fatalities	
	OLS	OLS	IV	IV	IV	IV
Syria Return (Logged)	0.050*** (0.012)	0.055*** (0.016)	0.048*** (0.012)	0.044 (0.032)	0.044*** (0.012)	0.042 (0.028)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.050*** (0.011)	-0.031** (0.014)	-0.058*** (0.020)	-0.045 (0.033)	-0.041*** (0.016)	-0.029 (0.029)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.004*** (0.001)	-0.003*** (0.001)	-0.003*** (0.001)	-0.004** (0.002)	-0.804* (0.448)	-1.327* (0.737)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.002*** (0.000)	0.001** (0.001)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.001 (0.002)	0.220** (0.098)	0.020 (0.446)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged DV	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
Sargan Statistics			2.966 (p = 0.227)	0.179 (p = 0.915)	2.199 (p = 0.333)	2.06 (p = 0.357)
Num. obs.	12080	1768	12080	1768	11940	1744

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Table A18: Estimations with Continuous Measure of Wartime Sufferings

A.20 Reliability of Key Informants

Because the ILA relies on local key informants, its measures may reflect reporting error as well as underlying conditions. Moreover, returnee-hosting settlements may receive greater monitoring and public attention, potentially improving informant reliability and generating differential measurement error.

Table A19 evaluates this possibility using two indicators available in ILA Rounds IV, VI, and VII: consistency between informant reports and field observations and informant reliability. Across OLS and IV specifications in both the full and restricted samples, neither refugee return nor its interaction with ISIS exposure predicts either measure. The main findings are therefore unlikely to be driven by differential reporting quality.

	Informant–Observation Match				Informant Reliability			
	OLS	IV	OLS	IV	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Syria Return (Logged)	0.005 (0.006)	0.027 (0.028)	0.005 (0.006)	0.030 (0.031)	-0.001 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Other Return (Logged)	-0.002 (0.003)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.005 (0.005)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.001 (0.003)	0.001 (0.004)	0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.000)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.009 (0.006)	-0.031 (0.028)	-0.005 (0.006)	-0.031 (0.031)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Other Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.001 (0.003)	-0.000 (0.003)	0.005 (0.005)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.003)	-0.001 (0.004)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.000)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged Conflict	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Full	Restricted	Restricted	Full	Full	Restricted	Restricted
Sargan Statistics		0.011 (p = 0.994)		0.005 (p = 0.998)		0.056 (p = 0.972)		0.001 (p = 1)
Num. obs.	8893	8893	1322	1322	9060	9060	1326	1326

***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.1

Table A19: Consistency and Reliability of IOM's Key Informants

A.21 Urban Versus Rural Areas

Supplementary Figure A12 replicates the IV estimations separately for urban and rural localities. The main results hold in both contexts.

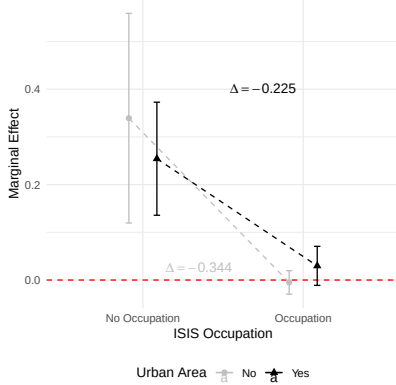


Figure A12: Urban Versus Rural Areas

A.22 Spatial Placebo Tests

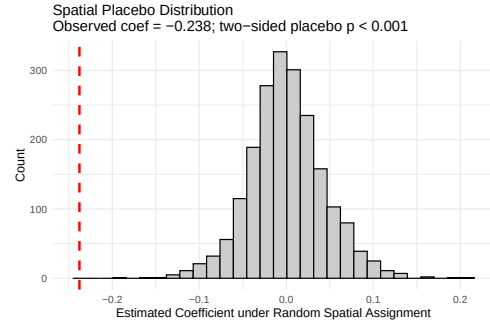


Figure A13: Spatial Placebo Tests

A.23 Additional Controls

In addition to the covariates included in the baseline specifications, I incorporate alternative measures of existing controls and several additional controls in the robustness analysis. Table A20 reports additional IV estimates. Columns 1–2 replace the binary ethnic-diversity indicator with the number of ethnic groups in the home community. Columns 3–4 use host-country diversity as a proxy for identity cleavages among returnees. Columns 5–6 interact ISIS occupation with logged IDP and IDP-returnee counts, while Columns 7–8 control for survey round interacted with inverse distance to the border. The results remain consistent with the main findings.

	Num. of Groups		Host Diversity		Occupation x IDP		Dist. to Border	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Syria Return (Logged)	0.192** (0.075)	0.208*** (0.079)	0.193 (0.138)	0.236 (0.145)	0.183** (0.072)	0.174** (0.075)	0.193*** (0.072)	0.181** (0.077)
Non-Syria Return (Logged)	-0.066*** (0.020)	-0.065* (0.039)	-0.053 (0.064)	-0.071 (0.081)	-0.063*** (0.020)	-0.058 (0.037)	-0.063*** (0.021)	-0.065* (0.037)
Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	-0.184** (0.075)	-0.235*** (0.079)	-0.183 (0.125)	-0.267** (0.131)	-0.174** (0.073)	-0.196*** (0.076)	-0.197*** (0.073)	-0.219*** (0.077)
No-Syria Return (Logged) x ISIS Occupation	0.060*** (0.021)	0.019 (0.036)	0.060 (0.046)	0.030 (0.062)	0.070*** (0.022)	0.031 (0.033)	0.072*** (0.022)	0.046 (0.033)
Full Control	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Settlement FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round-by-Governorate FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lagged Conflict	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sample	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted	Full	Restricted
	1.054	0.156	2.573	1.565	1.762	0.776	1.6	0.608
Sargan Statistics	(p = 0.59)	(p = 0.925)	(p = 0.276)	(p = 0.457)	(p = 0.414)	(p = 0.678)	(p = 0.449)	(p = 0.738)
Num. obs.	12080	1768	12080	1768	12080	1768	12080	1768

*** p < 0.01; ** p < 0.05; * p < 0.1

Table A20: Estimations with Additional Controls

B Micro-Level Mechanisms: A Survey Experiment in Ethiopia

Although the settlement-level analysis in Iraq provides strong evidence that geographic alignment in wartime exposure between returnees from violent host countries and stayees from ISIS-occupied areas is associated with lower levels of communal violence after refugee return, a key limitation of administrative-level data is that it cannot directly examine individual responses toward returnees with different displacement experiences or the psychological mechanisms—such as empathy and identity recategorization—that may shape these outcomes.

To examine these micro-level mechanisms, I plan to complement the observational analysis with a preregistered online survey experiment in Ethiopia, conducted during August–October 2026. The study uses a single-profile conjoint design in which respondents evaluate the profiles of four hypothetical returning refugees whose wartime experiences are randomly varied. The survey will recruit approximately 1,600 adults across locations that experienced different levels of violence during the Tigray War (2020–2022), including the heavily affected city of Mekelle, the relatively peaceful capital Addis Ababa, and cities with intermediate exposure such as Jijiga, Adama, and Hawassa.³³

The key experimental manipulation varies whether the returning refugee experienced violence during displacement. This attribute is interacted with respondents’ own wartime exposure, measured prior to treatment, to test whether shared exposure increases acceptance of returnees and reduces perceived security threats. By directly manipulating information about returnees’ wartime experiences, the experiment provides causal evidence on whether the settlement-level patterns observed in Iraq extend to a culturally different return setting. It also tests whether recognition of shared suffering increases respondents’ willingness to accept returnees, support reintegration assistance, and tolerate economic competition, while shedding light on the underlying psychological mechanisms of mutual empathy and shared identity as war survivors.

B.1 Research Design: Conjoint Experiment

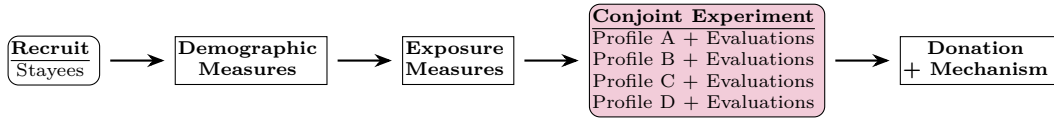


Figure B1: Conjoint Experiment Design and Survey Flow

The experiment uses a conjoint design. Figure B1 visualizes the survey flow. After the pre-treatment questions on respondents’ demographic characteristics and exposure to violence, they will be presented with a common baseline scenario stating that approximately 200 Ethiopian refugees who left the country during the recent conflict are expected to return and resettle in the respondent’s local community. The scenario notes that local authorities and community leaders are discussing how the return process will be managed. After that, respondents evaluate four hypothetical returnee profiles presented sequentially.

<i>In the coming months, around 200 refugees are expected to return to your local community. These returnees left Ethiopia during the recent conflict and are now planning to return. Below is one profile of a returning individual.</i>	
Attribute	Levels (randomly assigned)
Shared ethnic identity	From your ethnic group (50%) From a different ethnic group (50%)
Gender	Male (50%) Female (50%)
Violence exposure during displacement	No direct exposure to violence (50%) Was detained by authorities because of refugee status (25%) Was attacked by armed groups (25%)
Economic conditions during displacement	[Not mentioned] (50%) Faced severe economic hardship during displacement (50%)
Repatriation assistance	No assistance (33.3%) From UNHCR (33.3%) From Ethiopian Government (33.3%)

Table B1: Conjoint Profile Attributes and Randomization Probabilities

Table B1 details the four attributes and their levels used in the experiment. The key attribute of interest—returnees’ exposure to violence during displacement—takes one of four values: no direct exposure to violence, property damage due to fighting, detention by authorities because of refugee status, or attack by armed groups. Although the theory does not predict different effects across types of violence, I explore whether the magnitude of empathy and acceptance varies across specific forms of exposure. Including multiple types also helps ensure that the results are not driven by a single form of violence.

³³Assuming that 25–30% of respondents have past exposure to violence, the sample size provides 80% power to detect an interaction effect between the profiled returnee’s exposure to violence and the stayee (respondent)’s own exposure to violence of approximately 0.15 standard deviations.

To address the possibility that respondents may infer economic hardship from violence exposure—thereby conflating trauma-based empathy with sympathy for material deprivation—I independently randomize the returnee’s economic conditions during displacement. I also randomize whether the returnee shares the respondent’s ethnic identity, allowing the experiment to test conditional effects consistent with the settlement-level analysis in Iraq. Finally, people’s attitudes toward returnees may also be shaped by whether returnees receive economic assistance upon return and by who provides that assistance. By randomizing return assistance between non-receivers and receivers from foreign and domestic sources, I examine whether repatriation aid facilitates reintegration and whether its effects depend on the source of provision. I exclude other attributes, such as age and occupation, to concentrate statistical power on theoretically central comparisons and minimize cognitive burden. The order of the attributes will be randomized across respondents, following (Bansak et al., 2021), to separate attribute effects from ordering effects.

To ensure that respondents make absolute evaluations and to enhance ecological validity, the experiment employs a single-profile (one-profile-at-a-time) conjoint design in which respondents evaluate one returnee profile at a time (De la Cuesta et al., 2022). Each profile describes a returning refugee in a short integrated paragraph. For example: “**Abel is from XXX (your ethnic group)** [Ethnicity]. **He** [Gender] fled during the recent conflict and is now returning. During displacement, he **was attacked by armed groups** [Exposure] and **faced severe economic hardship** [Economic Hardship]. He received **no assistance upon return**. [Return Assistance]” Presenting profiles in narrative form reduces experimenter demand and mirrors how information about returnees is encountered in real-world settings.

B.2 Measuring Exposure to Violence

The key moderator is respondents’ wartime exposure during the Tigray War. Before answering sensitive questions, respondents receive a distress protocol that provides mental health resources and allows them to continue, pause, or end the survey while retaining compensation.³⁴ Those who continue report their pre-conflict residence and displacement history, followed by whether they or an immediate family member witnessed combat, experienced property destruction, lost someone to violence, or faced detention or harassment by armed forces. Each item includes a “prefer not to answer” option. I measure exposure using both a count of experienced events and an inverse-covariance-weighted index. Table B2 summarizes these measures.

Measure	Statement	Response Scale
Displacement	<i>During the Tigray conflict, what was your residential situation?</i>	Remained in my home community throughout Temporarily displaced within my home region Displaced to another Ethiopian region Fled to another country Other (specify)
	<i>[If displaced] How would you describe your safety and security during displacement?</i>	Generally safe Some safety concerns or insecurity Serious threats, violence, or persecution
Exposure to Violence	<i>During the Tigray conflict (2020–2022), did you or your immediate family experience any of the following? (Select all that apply)</i>	Witnessed armed combat Had home/property destroyed or damaged Lost family member or close friend to violence Detained or harassed by armed forces Prefer not to answer

Table B2: Measuring Wartime Experiences

B.3 Outcome Measures

The five primary outcomes measure acceptance of returnees, support for their land rights, perceived intergroup threat, preferences for equal assistance, and willingness to support organized opposition to their settlement. Table B3 presents the exact wording and response scales. Although these outcomes do not directly measure violence, they capture theoretically relevant precursors—including social acceptance, perceived legitimacy and threat, distributive fairness, and mobilization—that can determine whether communal disputes escalate.

³⁴The protocol explains that the upcoming questions concern conflict-related experiences and presents the three response options.

Outcome	Question	Scale
Acceptance	<i>How comfortable would you feel having people like [name] living in your neighborhood after they return?</i>	1–5
Land Claims	<i>Do you support recognizing land claims by returnees like [name] if the land belonged to their families before displacement?</i>	1–5
Inter-Group Threat	<i>If many refugees like [name] return to your community, how likely is serious conflict between returnees and local residents?</i>	1–5
Resource Allocation	<i>If your community receives humanitarian assistance, how should resources be distributed between returnees like [name] and residents who stayed?</i>	1–5
Collective Action	<i>If some people in your community organized to oppose returnees like [name] reclaiming land or settling nearby, how likely would you be to join them?</i>	1–5

Table B3: Outcome Measures

For one randomly selected profile, respondents complete mechanism measures capturing empathy toward the returnee, recognition of shared suffering, and perceived identity boundaries.³⁵ Respondents then complete a hypothetical donation task measuring their willingness to support returnee reintegration. Because this task captures general support for returnees rather than a response to the selected profile, a follow-up allocation question assesses whether support is directed specifically toward returnees who experienced violence during displacement or toward returnees facing general humanitarian needs, such as children’s schooling.

B.4 Estimation Strategies

To test whether recognition of shared exposure to violence influences respondents’ attitudes toward returning refugees, the core empirical test examines whether the treatment effects of violence-related attributes depend on stayees’ own wartime experiences. I estimate conditional average marginal component effects (AMCEs) by interacting the violence-exposure attribute with measures of respondents’ own exposure to wartime violence.

The heterogeneity analysis relies on respondents’ wartime experiences, High-Exp. Res._{*r*}, measured using two approaches. First, I distinguish respondents by survey location, classifying cities as high- or low-exposure depending on whether conflict-related fatalities during the Tigray War—based on ACLED data—exceed the national average. Second, I use individual-level measures of wartime experience. Respondents are grouped using a pre-treatment measure of self-reported exposure to violence (based on a top-quantile split) and their past displacement experience (previously displaced versus not displaced). The estimation strategy is:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot \text{Violence Exp.}_{r,i} + \beta_2 \cdot \text{Violence Exp.}_{r,i} \times \text{High-Exp. Res.}_{r,i} + \beta_3 \cdot \text{High-Exp. Res.}_{r,i} + X P_{r,i} \cdot \theta + X R_r \cdot \iota + \epsilon_{r,i}$$

Coefficient β_2 is the primary quantity of interest, capturing how the treatment effect differs for respondents with higher levels of wartime exposure relative to those with lower exposure. I also include other profile attributes ($X P_{r,i}$) and respondent-level covariates ($X R_r$) to improve estimation precision.

The coefficients correspond to the hypotheses as follows. Under Hypothesis 1 (Shared Exposure), I expect a positive effect of violent displacement experiences on attitudes toward returnees among respondents with high exposure to wartime violence; thus, $\beta_1 + \beta_2 > 0$. Under Hypothesis 2 (Perceived Threat), I expect a negative effect of violent displacement experiences among low-exposure respondents; thus, $\beta_1 < 0$. Finally, Hypothesis 3 (Boundary Hardening) predicts a negative baseline difference in attitudes toward returnees among high-exposure respondents, tested by $\beta_3 < 0$.

B.5 Planned Data Collection

The experiment has received IRB approval from the University of Pittsburgh and Wolaita Sodo University in Ethiopia. Results from the pilot survey experiment (planned for September 2026) and the main experiment (planned for October 2026) will be reported once data collection is completed.

³⁵I construct inverse-covariance-weighted indices for three mechanism categories, while also reporting item-level estimates (Anderson, 2008).